

A Brief Insight to Visishtadvaita Philosophy

Vishnu Sreenivas

Dedication

This book is dedicated to my Late Grandmother, K. Vedavathy, and Late Grandfather, T. Srinivasachar, without whose influences I would have never taken an interest in Indian culture and philosophy.

Foreword

There is always a quest in every human being's as to know what life is and what happens after one's death. To answer such questions, this book will act as a guide. In this book, I will try to put forth in detail the intricacies of the aathma's existence in a body; its upliftment to attain a better mortal body or its ever-longing strife to attain moksham or liberation. This book aims to be a guide to those who would like to gain an insight about the jeevaathma and how it increases moksham and reaches the Paramaathma according to the Visishta Advaita Philosophy as given by Bhagavad Ramanujar and the acharyas who came before and after him.

1. Tattvas

The Visishta Advaita Philosophy speaks of three tattvas or three ways one can interpret creation. Those three tattvas are:

- i) Chith or the Jeevaathma
- ii) Achith or the Prakriti
- iii) Ishwara or the Paramaathma

Chith or the Jeevaathma refers to the souls of any living being in creation.

Achith or the Prakriti refers to nature or surroundings in which the soul would reside in.

Ishwara or the Paramaathma refers to the Lord, who is the Almighty Supreme Ruler of the universe.

In nature, we observe hundreds of thousands of living creatures, each of which possesses a soul. Therefore, we can say that Achith acts as a residence for all that is Chith. From this, we can draw the inference that Chith and Achith are inseparable from one another.

As for Ishwara, He dwells in both Chith and Achith. Thus, Chith and Achith are inseparable from Ishwara.

From this, we establish what is known as Sharira-Shariri Bhaava, i.e., the relationship between the dweller and that which dwells. We see that Ishwara lives within Chith and Achith and brings them together. Hence Ishwara Tattva is treated as the Ultimate, which controls everything in creation

2. Aathma

The soul that is otherwise known as Chith, Aathma, or Jeeva, is an independent entity that should not be confused with the functions of the body or its brain. It is free of thought, emotion, will, or intelligence. It is not situated in any particular part of the body. It pervades in the entirety of space, throughout every atom in every living being. When an organism dies and is burnt or buried, the soul does not die. The aathma is incapable of death. It is eternal. The aathma is not visible, is incomprehensible, and is unchangeable. The aathma is constituted by knowledge and bliss and is self-luminous.

The knowledge that constitutes the aathma is of two types, namely

- i) Dharmi Jnanam
- ii) Dharmabhuta Jnanam

Dharmi Jnanam helps the aathma be aware of itself at all times whereas, the Dharmabhuta Jnanam helps it know its body, the body's surroundings, all the people in the body's lifetime, and the objects beyond the body. Thus, when the body expires, the aathma loses its Dharmabhuta Jnanam. The best comparison to understand this concept is that of a luminous lantern. The aathma can be interpreted as a bright flame. The body is the fuel of the fire. Even if the body expires, the aathma can find refuge in

another vessel, which will act as fuel to the eternal flame. For the fire to be genuinely immortal, it must merge with the Paramaathma. Upon merging with the Paramaathma, the aathma would not require any new body and will know eternal bliss as it reached its final destination.

3. Eternal bliss in Sri Vaikuntham

On attaining moksham, the aathma gains unrestricted access to Paramapadam or Sri Vaikuntham, which is the highest realm attainable, according to Visishta Advaita Philosophy. It is said that upon reaching Paramapadam, the aathma enjoys four experiences eternally. These four experiences are called:

- i) Saalokya: Being able to live in the same world as the Lord.
- ii) Saarupya: Having the same appearance as the Lord with Chaturbhujam, Shanku, Chakram, Gadha, and Padmam.
- iii) Samipa: Always being near the Lord.
- iv) Saayujya: Being able to partake in the Lord's bliss and enjoy it just the same as Him.

The Dharmabhuta Jnanam achieved in Paramapadam is eternal and complete. The Lord restores to the new muktha-aathma eight qualities, i.e.;

- i) Being free from any sin
- ii) Being free of any aging
- iii) Being free of death
- iv) Being free of sorrow

- v) Being free of hunger
- vi) Being free of thirst
- vii) Being endowed with all that the muktha-aathma desires
- viii) Finally, offering the muktha-aathma no return to samsaaram or bhu-lokam.

Therefore, the ultimate goal for any jeevaathma is to attain moksham or liberation from the cycle of birth and death.

Moksham or mukti provides what is known as Paripurna Brahma-Anubhavam, which is a complete understanding of the Paramaathma. We can understand the Lord's nature (swarupa), His delightful nature (vigraha), His auspicious qualities (kalyana gunam), His ability to put time on hold or let it run according to His will (Leela Vibuti and Nithya Vibhuti). The aathma's enjoyment is eternal and will always result in service to the Paramaathma at all times under any given situation.

4. The aathma, as mentioned and described by the Bhagavad Gita

The main takeaways that one can take from the Gita when talking about the aathma are as follows:

- i) The number of births that are taken by a jeevaathma is innumerable:
The Lord tells Arjuna that both of them have taken numerous incarnations together in this world together. But only the Lord remembers all of them whereas, Arjuna does not. The Lord elucidates that He can remember everything as He is eternal knowledge and pure.

ii) Nature of the aathma:

The Lord tells Arjuna that just as birth, childhood, youth, and old age are inevitable stages of a human's growth in life, similarly, it is unavoidable for the soul to find a new body after its current vessel expires. The Lord says the soul is unborn, indestructible, and never dies. It is eternal. Fire cannot burn it, water cannot moisten it, and wind cannot dry it. Just as a man casts off old worn-out garments, the soul casts off old worn-out bodies and enters a new one.

iii) Effect of the three Gunas on the manifested aathma:

Grossly speaking, three Gunas quickly bind to the body, which in turn impacts the aathma. The three Gunas are:

iii.i) Sattva Gunam: This Gunam links to the ones who engage in activities that are pure and linked to seeking genuine knowledge of the Supreme.

iii. ii) Rajas Gunam: This Gunam links to those who engage in activities that are driven by passion, thirst, and action.

iii. iii) Taamasa Gunam: This Gunam links to those who engage in ignorance, negligence, and lethargy.

The three Gunas bind to the body at the time of death, granting different realms to the aathma upon bondage. If Sattva Gunam predominantly occupies the body, then the aathma attains Brahmaloam, a realm of knowledge. If Rajas Gunam predominantly occupies the body, then the person is reborn as a radical or a person of action. Finally, if Taamasa

Gunam mainly occupies the body, then the person is reborn as an irrational being.

iv) Attaining Liberation

The one who declares that their devotion to the Lord transcends the three Gunas becomes qualified to attain moksham. The Lord tells Arjuna to relinquish all dharma and take refuge solely in Him. He will liberate you from your sins and grant you moksham.

v) What sort of person can reach Paramapadam?

Lord Krishna declares that a person who is free from pride, delusion, evil, attachment, self-obsession, desire, pleasure, and pain can attain Paramapadam.

5. Artha Panchakam



Swami Desikan

Swami Desikan is considered to be an incarnation of the divine bell of Sri Venkateshwara Swami of Tirumalai. Swami Desikan was born here in Tooppul to Sri Anantha Suri and Devi Totaramba. By birth, Swami Desikan was named Venkatanatha. When Swami Desikan was just five years of age, he was taken by his maternal uncle, Kidambi Appular, to attend a discourse by Nadadhoor Ammal, a revered Sri Vaishnava Scholar at the time. As soon as Nadadhoor Ammal saw Venkatanatha, he saw a divine radiance in the child and stopped the lecture that he was delivering to hug the child affectionately. After this, when Nadadhoor Ammal said that he had forgotten where he had finished his discourse, Venkatanatha reminded him as to where he had stopped his lecture. This act astonished the crowd as

they had never seen a five-year-old boy comprehend the deep intricacies of philosophical knowledge that was being discussed. It was then that Nadadhoor Ammal predicted and blessed Venkatanatha that he, in the future, would become the torch-bearer to spread Sri Vaishnavism everywhere.

At each place, he composed many different works in languages such as Tamil, Sanskrit, Prakrit, and Manipravala (a mixture of Sanskrit and Tamil) that revealed his ingenuity creativity, logic, linguistic expertise, devotional fervor, and erudite scholarship.

Some of his greatest works include:

- 1) Hayagreeva Stotram
- 2) Sudarshana Ashtakam
- 3) Paduka Sahasram
- 4) Abheetistavam
- 5) Achyuta Shatakam
- 6) Daya Shatakam
- 7) Hamsa Sandesham

8) Sri Stuti

9) Yadavyudayam

10) Kamasikashatakam

The Artha Panchakam, composed by Swami Desikan is a set 11 Pasurams dedicated to Sri Varadaraja Perumal of Kanchipuram. The 11 Pasurams are assigned to two of each of the five doctrines or truths of the Artha Panchakam.

The five doctrines discussed are as follows:

The Swarupam of Parabrahman.

The Swarupam of the jeevaathma.

The obstacles that prevent us from reaching Paramapadam

The means to moksham: Bhakti and Prapatti

The supreme goal of Bhagavat Anubhavam

Now we will see each of the 11 Pasurams and understand its meaning.

Amalan aviyAtha-sudar aLavillaa-AarAmudham

amala uru guNangaL aNi aayudhangal adiyavarkaL

amala azhiyAtha nahar azhinthu yezhum kaavudan yellAm

Kamalayudan arasALum Karigiri mERk-KaavalanaE ... 1

Meaning:

Swarupam of Parabramham

This samsaaram is a karma bhumi. The Lord plays a sport of distributing karma-phalam to the aathma as per what it had accumulated through the course of its janmam. There are no limits to the Lord's auspicious gunas. He has “Swaroopo-Niroopaka Viseshanam and Niroopita-Swaroopo Viseshanam” among his gunas. Viseshanam is a characteristic, distinguishing feature that sets Him apart from others.

The Swaroopo Niroopaka Gunas are five in number:

Satyatvam: He is invariant at all times.

Jnatatvam: His knowledge is eternal.

Anantatvam: He is present at all places at all times.

Anandatvam: His presence brings out eternal bliss.

Amalatvam: He is the only one who is blemishless.

uLLa poruL anaitthukkum uruva nilai karumangaL

teLLisaivin vasamAkkitt-thihazhnthu uyirAi uRaihinRAn

naLL iruL theertthu adiyavarkku nalam kodukkum ThiruvudanE

VaLLal AruLALar yenum VaaraNa veRppu IRayavanE ... 2

Meaning:

Everything in creation is under the control of the Lord's Sankalpam.

Attigiri Nathan and Perundevi Thayaar pervade in all objects of creation and control them by their will. The Lord will sever all the bonds of samsaram for those who perform sharanagti and will grant them moksham.

BhUtha vudal pulankaL manam pul aavi punthi yenum

yAthum alanAi ilahi yaann yenum inn nuNN aRivAi

chEthanAnAi adimaiyumAmm yuirkellAm tiNNuyirAi

theethal inRi thihazhum Seer Athtigiri Thirumaal ... 3

Meaning:

Swaroopam of jeevaathma.

The body is constituted by the Pancha-bhutas, the senses, the mind, prana, and jnana. This is distinctly different from the jeevaathma. The jeevaathma is of diminutive size, and it differs from body to body. The only aspect that is common to all jeevaathmas is the property of being a servant to the Lord.

taan adaittha guNam karuvi tamm girisai vazhi ozhukki

oon yedutthu uNDu umizhnthu uzhalum yuirkku yellAm uyirAhi

kaan nadatthi Kamalayudan kaNDuhanthu viLayAdym

tEn yeduttha solaihaL soozh Thiru AtthiyUrAnE ... 4

Meaning:

The Lord witnesses how the jeevaathma enjoys the karma-phalam that was provided.

As seen in the first Pasuram, the Lord distributes the karma-phalam to every jeevaathma. As the jeevaathma begins to experience the karma-phalam, it begins to detest it, and desires start to occupy the body. Due to

this desire, the jeevaathma is sent continuously back into the ocean, known as samsara, to fulfill its desires. Perarulalan, along with Perundevi Thayaar, enters the jeevaathmas and bear witness to how the jeevaathma enjoys its karma-phalam.

uyyum uRavu isayAthE otthavarkkE adimayumAi

poy uruvai tamakku yERRip-pulan koNDa payanE koNDu

iyuRavum aar iruLum al-vazhiyum adainthavarkkE

meyyaruL seythidum ThirumAl vEzha malai MEyavanE ... 5

Meaning:

The Moksha Virodhi

The jeevaathma does not remember its inherent, inescapable links to the Lord and unfortunately gets associated with another bonded jeevaathma. The jeevaathma starts to engage itself in trivial pleasures because it cannot recall the difference between itself and the body in which it is temporarily stationed. Such a jeevaathma fails to find the right Acharya and is therefore full of arrogance and ignorance. The jeevaathma feels agony and engages itself in inauspicious activities. The Lord feels pity for such jeevaathmas and opens up a path to find the right Acharya and reengage in bhakti so that

it may qualify for sharanagati and prapatti, thus allowing the Lord to liberate it from its cycle of birth and death.

vidhai muLayin nyAyatthAl adi illA vinai adaivE

sathai udala nAlvahaikkum saraNamaLippAn yenat-thihazndhu

padhavi aRiyAthu pazham pAzhil uzhalhinRArkku

sithaivu ill aruL tarum Thiru AtthinaharAnE ... 6

Meaning:

The bondages of Samsaaram and Karma

The Lord protects and blesses all jeevaathmas, showing them ways of redemption, leading them to moksham and freedom from being reborn as either *Deva*, *Manushya*, *Thiyak*, and *Sthavara*. He showers his grace eternally, leading it to moksham. vidhai muLayin nyAyam refers to an age-old debate/question. What came first, the seed or the plant? This is hard to tell.

Similarly, our Acharyas came up with the question of what came first, the body or the karma-phalam? The answer that was decided was both karma and the body is intertwined as whatever karma the previous vessel of the aathma performed so that it would reap the karma-phalam leading into the

next vessel. Thus both karma and body are timeless and ancient. This was the conclusion that our Acharyas arrived.

yama niyama aasanangaL iyal aavi pulanadakkam

tamathu aRiyum dhAraNaikaL tArAi aRA ninaivu ozhukkam

samam udaya samAdhi nalam sAthippArkku ilakku aahum

amarar thozhum Atthigiri ambhyutthAL AaramudhE ... 7

Meaning:

Bhakti and Prapatti Upayam

The Lord severs all the bonds of Samsaram for those who practice bhakti-yogam in its totality along with its eight angams. The eight angams of bhakti-yogam are mentioned as follows:

(1) Yamam (ahimsa, Sathyam, non-stealing, control of Kaamam et al.)

(2) Niyamam (Parisuddhi, Satisfaction with what one has, the performance of

vratham/tapas, efforts at Vedantha Paricchayam, Saathvika Thyagam)

(3) Aasanam (Yogic postures like Padhmasanam)

(4) Pranayamam (Control of Breath)

(5) PrathyAhAram (Control of senses & Turning them away

from the worldly sukhams and temptations)

(6) Dharanai(Imprint of Bhagavan's Tirumeni in one's mind)

(7) Dhyanam (uninterrupted meditation of the Lord)

(8) Samadhi (reaching a state of anubhavam through dhyAnam,

wherein the performer feels that he is seeing the Lord directly).

One can reach moksham by opting for either bhakti-yogam or by performing sharanagati at the feet of an Acharya.

puhal ulahil illAthu ponnaruL kaNDu uRRavaRkkum

ahalahilA anbarkkum anRE TannaruL kodutthup-

pahalathanAl pazham kangul vidivikkum PankayatthAL

ahalahilEn yenRu uRayum Atthigiri aruL muhile ... 8

Meaning:

Elaboration on Prapatti

Attigiri Nathan is compared to a dark cloud in the rainy season, full of water, ready to shower at any time. Similarly, the Lord is a cloud of daya and karunai. Those who perform prapatti to the Lord shall forever feel the grace of the Lord showering over them. Before performing prapatti at the feet of the Lord, it is necessary first to seek permission at the feet of Mahalakshmi to help us successfully perform prapatti at the Lord's feet.

iru vilangu vidutthu iruntha siRai vidutthOr naadiyinAl

karu nilankaL kadakkum vazhi kAvalarAl kadatthuvitthup-

perunilam kaNDu uyir uNarnthu piriyaAmal aruL seyyum

uru nalam koNDu uRum ThiruvOdu uyar AtthigiriyAnE ... 9

Meaning:

Elaboration on Moksha Swaroopam

Mahalakshmi has roopam and kalyana gunams. These allow Her to stay eternally with the Lord. When one performs sharanagathi to the Lord, the

jeevaathma becomes capable of entering Sri Vaikuntham and forgetting the burdens of the Achiraadi Margam. Paapam and Punyam bind to the jeevaathma before performing sharanagathi. Once sharanagathi is completed, not paapam nor punyam can link with the aathma as the Lord offers a permanent place by His holy feet for all eternity.

Tamm ThirumAthudanE thAmm tani arasAy uRaihinRa

antham ilA pEr inbatthil adiyavarOdu yemai sErtthu

munthi izhanthana yellAm muhizhhikka tanthu aatkoLLum

antham ilA aruLAzhi Atthigirit-ThirumAlE ... 10

Meaning:

Gaining of Sarva Kainkaryam during Moksham

The Lord and Mahalakshmi eternally rule over Sri Vaikuntham. When the Lord grants moksham to any jeevaathma, He turns the jeevaathma into a mukthaathma, giving them a place alongside the Nitya-Sooris and other fellow mukthaathmas, allowing the mukthaathma to perform kainkaryam to the Lord eternally.

Ayan paNiyum Atthigiri AruLALar adiyiNai mEl

nayankaL seRi Kacchi nagar nAnnmaRayOr nallaruLAl

payankaL ivai anaitthum yenap-paNDuraitthAr padi uraittha

viyan kalaikaL yeerainthum vEdhiyarkku iniyanavE ...11

Meaning:

Phala Stuti

This prabhandham was created in tune with the upadesams of Poorva Acharyas and has been realized with the anugraham of Parama Bhagavathas, who have the good fortune of enjoying the dhivya soundharyam and Kalyana gunams of Lord Varadarajan, who presides over Atthigiri . Only Mahans with the familiarity of the meanings of Vedams can relate to them and enjoy the sweetness of the implications of these Paasurams.

6. The vital, crucial role of an Acharya

A person who understands that he lacks the prescribed qualifications or ability to follow Karma, Jnana, and Bhakti but has the conviction and a longing desire to reach the Lord has a smooth and sure path laid out for him. All one must do is seek out an Acharya who will act as the spiritual guide. One must remain devoted and steadfast, with absolute faith that the Acharya will see them through in their spiritual journey to attain the Supreme. The only requirements are total desire, devotion, and faith in the Acharya. If a disciple follows the teachings of their Acharya, they will obtain all the benefits of *dharma*, *artha*, *kama*, and *moksha*.

7. Sriman Narayana is the first Acharya

There are many reasons why the Lord is attributed to our first Acharya. The following can be considered as the most significant reasons:

- a) The Lord taught the Vedas to Lord Brahma.
- b) The Lord revealed the ***Dwaya Mantram*** to a scared Mahalakshmi when Madhu-Kaithaba stole the Vedas.
- c) Through the teachings propagated to Lord Brahma, He made sure that man reaps the benefit of the Vedas.
- d) The Lord graced the four sons of Lord Brahma- Sanatkumara, Sanaka, Sananda, and Sanatsujata, and through them, He propagated *Hita*.
- e) He is present as the *Antharyami* (the one who governs from inside), of great souls like Devarishi Narada, Parasara, and Parankusha.
- f) The Lord incarnated as Hamsa, Hayagriva, Nara-Narayana, Sri Krishna and propagated *Tattva-Hita-Purushartha*.

- g) He made a great soul, such as Bhishma, give the world great teachings such as Neeti Shastra.
- h) At the end of Dwapara Yugam, when the teachings of the Pancharatra Agamas were lost, the Lord reincarnated as Sankarshana to re-establish them.
- i) To establish the *Acharya-Sishya* relationship, He incarnated as Nara-Narayana and taught Nara the ***Tirumantram*** to Nara at Badrinath.
- j) As the access to the Vedas became restricted, the Lord, through the Azhwars, gave the world the Nalayira Divya Prabandhangal or the Tamil Veda, which propagated the message of the Vedas in a local language.
- k) When the Buddhists tried to preach their teachings, which went against the Vedas, the Lord, through Acharya's teachings, re-established the Vedantic Philosophy.

8. The need for an Acharya in one's spiritual life

One who desires moksham must seek out an Acharya. When one seeks out an Acharya and surrenders at their feet, any sin will not pose any hindrance to moksham. Without an Acharya, regardless of how many ever good deeds we may commit in our lifetime, we will not be eligible for moksham.

Here are a few anecdotes that elucidate the role of an Acharya in our life.

Vishnu Dharmam tells the story of Kshethrabandhu, who retorted to evil ways but was reformed by a sage. The sage was pleased by Kshethrabandhu's attention span and advised him to chant the name of Govinda and that one day; the Lord would show him the path of righteousness, reforming him. Kshethrabandhu followed the sage's advice and gained Paramapadam.

Padmottara Puranam tells the story of Pundarika, who relentlessly practiced bhakti-yoga but could not get a glimpse of the Lord and hence became dejected. One day Pundarika encountered Devarishi Narada and explained to him what plight he was facing. Devarishi Narada told Pundarika not to worry and gave him the ***Ashtaakshara Mantram*** and told him to chant and meditate upon it. Pundarika earnestly followed Devarishi Narada's advice and attained Paramapadam.

9. The duties of an Acharya

The Acharya must first master the three divine secrets and their meaning in their entirety. Only after learning it in its entirety is he supposed to pass it on to his pupils.

The Acharya must perform ***Panchasamskaram***, which includes initiation to the three divine mantras, namely the ***Tirumantram***, ***Dwaya Mantram***, and ***Charama Shloka***.

The Acharya must impart in privacy to the disciple seeking moksham the inner meanings of the three ***Rahasyams***. The disciple, in turn, must reflect with utmost concentration the implications of the mantras and how they can conduct themselves accordingly to attain moksham. Living per the Acharya's instruction will relieve one from all sin and grant them a state free from fear about anything.

We must understand that the Lord and Mahalakshmi are the controllers of creation, sustenance, and destruction of all Chith and Achith. We also have to realize that the Lord is present as Antharyami inside every single one of us and that He will grant the karma-phalam to all our actions. Knowing the Lord's unique position, we must try only to seek Him out and nobody else. From time immemorial, we see the importance of an Acharya through the course of our history in the form of Swetaketu-Uddalaka, Brighu-Varuna, Maithreyi-Yagnavalka, Sanatkumara-Narada, Yama-Nachiketa, Prajapati-Indra, Vasishta-Rama, Sandipani-Krishna.

10. Performance of Panchasamskaram

By resorting to an Acharya and gaining his acceptance, the person will soon realize, by the grace of the Acharya, true knowledge, non-attachment to worldly pleasures, and devotion to the Lord starts to bloom like a flower. In Srivaishnava Sampradayam, the ***panchasamskaram*** is the most crucial ceremony performed by the Acharya. The Acharya, out of compassion, without any expectations, accepts the disciple regardless of their caste or creed. The Acharya then performs ***panchasamskaram***, and then the disciple becomes a Sri Vaishnava. Being a Sri Vaishnava is not determined by birth. This is the reason why one can see men and women from all communities and all walks of life as a Srivaishnava.

The ***panchasamskaram***, as the name suggests, consists of five samskarams, namely,

- I) **Tapa Samaskaram:** The Acharya embosses the impressions of the Panchajanya Shankam and the Sudharshana Chakram on the left and right arms of the disciple.
- II) **Pundra Samskaram:** The Acharya makes the disciple aware of the places in the body where the *upavyuha* forms of the Lord Sriman Narayana are to be worshipped. Each *upavyuha-sthanam* is represented by one of the twelve *thiruman-kapu* adorned by the disciple. The *tiruman* represents the Lord, whereas the *Sricharnam* represents Mahalakshmi. The worship of the Lord is performed by holding the hands in *Anjali-mudra* and reciting “*Keshavaya Namaha*” prefixed by the *Pranava*. Similarly, Devi Mahalakshmi is worshipped, reciting “*Sriyai Namaha*” prefixed by the *Pranava*.

- III) Nama Samskaram:** The Acharya adds the suffix of dasan to the disciple's name, indicating the disciple is now an eternal servant to the Lord and Swami Ramanujar.
- IV) Mantra Samskaram:** Of all the five samskarams performed, this is the most important without an iota of doubt. The mantras received when this samskaram is being delivered are together known as the ***Rahasya Trayam*** or the three divine secrets.
- V) Yagna Samskaram:** The Acharya teaches the disciple the ways of *Bhagavadh Aaradhana* and the methods to perform Salagrama pooja.

11. Guru Parampara

In this section, we shall see the stories of the Purva-Acharyas(11.1) and the life story of Swami Ramanujar(11.2) and then try to map the lineage of gurus according to both the Tenkalai and Vadagalai Sampradayms(11.3).

11.1.1 Namazhwar



Namazhwar

Forty-Three days had passed since Lord Sri Krishna had ascended to Sri Vaikuntham. A childless couple, Kari and Udayanangai, visited Tirukurungudi to pray for the birth of a child. It is said that they requested the Lord for a child who would be just like Him. As none in this universe is comparable to Him, it is noted that Nambi Himself

reincarnated as Namazhwar. Thus in the Vaikasi month under Visaka Nakshathram, Namazhwar was born. As soon as he was born, he exhibited very peculiar behavior in the form of not crying or suckling. The couple in concern is said to have taken the baby to the Adinatha Perumal Temple to pray to the Lord for the baby's well-being. Namazhwar is also said to be an amshavataram of Sri Vishwakshenar, who is said to be third in line in the Acharya Parampara after the Lord Sriman Narayana and Mahalakshmi Thayaar. The couple is said to have tied a cradle near the Tamarind tree that was present in the temple courtyard.



Divine Tamarind Tree

The baby is said to have crawled out of the cradle and crawled into a small crater-like space within the tree, and started a deep meditation. The baby is said to have stayed in this meditative state for sixteen years. At this time, Madurakavi Azhwar is said to have been at Ayodhya and offering argyam as per his Nityakarmam when he saw a blinding light at the edge of the horizon. Recognizing the meditative nature of the divine light is said to have started to follow the light. In pursuit of the light,

Madurakavi Azhwar is said to have traveled south, crossing Tiruvenkatam, then Tiruvallikeni, then Sri Rangam, then Madurai, and finally he reached Kurugur. When Madurakavi Azhwar reached the divine tree, he saw a child in a deep meditative state and was worried if the child was still alive or not. Madurakavi Azhwar is said to have thrown a rock near the boy to test his consciousness. When the boy opened his eyes, Madurakavi Azhwar was said to have asked a question, "**Sethathin Vayatrill Siriyadhu Pirandhaal Yeththai Thindru Enge Kiddakum?**" Madurakavi Azhwar was referring to the Jeevaathma. Madurakavi Azhwar asked that when the jeevaathma enters a lifeless body, how would it survive? What would it feed on, and how would it survive? This is when Namazhwar is said to have first spoken by saying, "**Aththaith Thindru Ange Kidakkum.**". Namazhwar's reply told that the lifeless body would experience the pleasures and pains of life before attaining paramapadam or moksham. Madurakavi Azhwar was so stunned by the boy's response that he begged to be his disciple. Madurakavi Azhwar composed 11 pasurams in praise of his Acharya, Swami Namazhwar, known as **Kanninun Shiruthambu**, which are included among the 4000 Nalayira Divya Prabandham.

When Namazhwar was ready to attain paramapadam, Madurakavi Azhwar asked Namazhwar with full of tears, what to do next. Namazhwar advised Madurakavi Azhwar to boil the waters of Tamraparni, and he said that an idol would form during the boiling of the water. Madurakavi Azhwar did as per Namazhwar's advice. When he had boiled the waters of Tamraparni, He got an idol of Bhagavad Ramanuja. He was surprised to see that the idol was different from what he had expected. He went to Namazhwar with the idol, and the latter told him

that this idol was that of a Bhavishyadhacharya (Future Guru) and that he would be born 4000 years from then. He again advised boiling the waters of Tamraparni. Madurakavi Azhwar once again boiled the waters of Tamraparni and finally got the idol of Namazhwar.

11.1.2 Nathamunigal



Nathamunigal is considered to be the second guru of the Sri Vaishnava Guru Parampara. He is believed to have been born near Viranarayanpuram near modern-day Mannargudi in what is believed to be 823 AD. He is credited with the resurgence and the compilation of the Naalayira Divyaprabandhangal.

At one point, all of the Naalayira Divyaprabandhangal were lost except for ten pashurams that were being sung at this temple. Here, Naathamunigal heard this, and the verses told ten out of a thousand pashurams. This had Naathamunigal intrigued as to where the other nine hundred and ninety pashurams had disappeared. These ten pashurams also spoke of Kurugur(present-day Azhwar Tirunagari) Sadagopan(Namazhwar). Thus Naathamunigal went in search of Namazhwar. Upon reaching Kurugur and enquiring about these ten pashurams, the locals denied knowing of the ten pashurams that he asked for, but they knew of eleven other pashurams. Naathamunigal recited these eleven pashurams twelve thousand times in front of the divine tamarind tree where Namazhwar had once resided. Upon completion of the recitation, Namazhwar is said to have appeared in front of Naathamunigal and blessed him with the thousand pashurams sung by him as well as the three thousand other pashurams which were sung by the nine other azhwars. Nathamunigal is said to have taught the Naalayira Divyaprabandhangal to his two nephews at Srirangam and introduced them at the Sri Ranganathaswamy Temple, where he served as the temple administrator.

The ritual of worship, as followed in Vishnu Temples, is based on two early standard works. The first is Vaikhanasa Sutra which probably belongs to the Krishna Yajurveda school. The other is the Panchratra Agama, which belongs to the extensive Tantra literature, believed to have been composed by Lord Sriman Narayana himself. The Agama has a peculiar philosophy of its own, the Bhagavata Cult, which is very old and is referred to in the Mahabharata and Badarayana Sutras. Nathamunigal made a provision for the recitation of Tamil Vedas on appropriate occasions during the main festivals of the Lord.

Nathamunigal is said to have attained Paramapadam at Gangaikona Cholapuram.

Nathamunigal's grandson Yamunacharyar became the torch-bearer of Sri Vaishnava Philosophy.

11.1.3 Manakkal Nambigal



Manakkaal Nambi was born as Rama Misrar in Manakkaaal near Trichy. He was the disciple of Uyyakondar, who was the prime disciple of Nathamunigal. Manakkaal Nambi served his Acharya for 12 years in which his Acharya's wife attained Paramapadam. After his Acharya's wife attained Paramapadam, Manakkaal Nambi took care of his Acharya, his house, and his children. One day Uyyakondar's children were crossing the Kaveri River when they came across a puddle, which they were

hesitant to cross. Seeing this scene, Manakkaal Nambi fell face front and asked the girls to use his body as a bridge to cross over to the other side. When Uyyakondar came to know of this incident, he was very impressed with his disciple and immediately performed the dwayamantropadesham. Before attaining Paramapadam, Uyyakondar instructs Manakkaal Nambi that he would become the Acharya to Yamunacharar(Alavandaar), who was Nathamunigal's grandson. He also instructed Manakkaal Nambi to perform panchasamskaram to Yamunacharyar and groom him to become the torch-bearer of the Sri Vaishnava Philosophy.

11.1.4 Yamunacharyar



Yamunacharyar was born as the son of Iswara Muni and as a grandson to Nathamunigal. He was born on the banks of the Yamuna River; hence he got the name of Yamunacharyar. He studied under Manakkaal Nambi, who was an expert in Mimamsa. After mastering Sanskrit and Tamizh grammar, he had composed a shloka which loosely translated to "he would destroy the poets who were looking cheaply for publicity instead of performing their duties of studying various literature." This news reached the ears of Aakiaazhwaan, who was the royal poet to the Pallava kings whose capital was situated in Gangai Kondapuram near Srirangam. The Pallava king was a staunch Shaivite whereas, his wife was a staunch Vaishnavite. The queen asked the king to hold an open debate in the court between Aakiaazhwaan and Yamunacharyar to decide who was a better poet. Thus the king sent a royal palanquin to receive Yamunacharyar to hold an open debate in the royal court. Before the discussion began, the king announced that whoever would win the debate would receive half of his kingdom as a prize. The king was confident that Aakiaazhwaan would win the contest. Aakiaazhwaan let Yamunacharyar open the discussion as he was younger and said he would refute any statement that Yamunacharyar would place in front of him. Thus, Yamunacharyar began the debate with three remarks.

1. Aakiaazhwaan's mother is not childless.
2. The king is all capable.
3. The queen is a true pathivratha naari.

Aakiaazhwaan started to think hard as to how he would refute the three statements that were placed before him. As hard as he tried to think, there was no way he could refute the statements placed before him without insulting his mother, the king, and

the queen. Aakiaazhwaan was dumbfounded and asked Yamunacharyar to refute his statements. Yamunacharyar quickly refuted the three statements as follows:

1. Aakiaazhwaan's mother is childless as, according to shastras, if a parent has only one child who does not care for the parent, it's as good as being childless.
2. The king was not all capable as he was only capable of ruling his stipulated piece of land.
3. The queen could not be considered as a true pathivratha naari as, according to shastras, when a woman is getting married, she is first married to Gandharva, Agni, and Soma before being married to the groom. Thus she is not a true pathivratha naari.

Aakiaazhwaan understands Yamunacharyar's mastery and asks to become his disciple. Even the queen was so impressed by Yamunacharyar's responses that she gave him the title of Aalavandaar. As promised, the king gave Aalavandhaar half of his kingdom. Thus Aalavandaar, who was born as a brahmin, became a king and became busy with administrative activities. To remind him of his true duties, Manakkaal Nambi tries to meet his disciple, but his efforts are in vain as the royal guards stop him from meeting Yamunacharyar. Thus, Manakkaal Nambi, in a scheme to reform his disciple, befriends a cook in the royal kitchen and secretly starts to feed the king thoothuvalai keerai (a green leafy vegetable), which is a type of sattvic food. Aalavandaar starts to like this vegetable, and one day the cook was instructed not to serve it. Thus when one day he was not served with thoothuvalai keerai, Aalavandaar approached the cook and asked him why he did not serve thoothuvalai keerai that day. The cook said he was following the instructions of an elderly Sri Vaishnava Acharya. Aalavandaar went out seeking this Acharya and realized that it was none

other than Manakkaal Nambi. He invites Manakkaal Nambi to his royal court, gives him a royal seat, and performs all the stipulated athithi sathkaaram to Manakkaal Nambi. Manakkaal Nambi reminds Yamunacharyar of his duties and starts to teach him the Bhagavad Gita and its meaning. Aalavandaar became immersed in Bhagavath-Dyaanam and decided to give up his life as a king to become an aesthetic at the feet of Sri Ranganathar.

His famous works include:

- Chathusloki
- Stotraratnam - a prayer in praise of Lord Sriman Narayana
- Siddhitrayam - consisting of (i) Atmasiddhi. (ii) Samvitsiddhi and (iii) Iswarasiddhi which describe the Vishistadvaita school of thought, illustrating a relation between the soul, god, and the universe
- Agama Pramanya - stating the authority of Pancharatra agama
- Maha Purusha Nirnayam - describing that the ultimate reality is the god-goddess pair Sri and Narayana
- Gitartha Sangraha - a commentary on the Bhagavad Gita
- Nityam
- Mayavada Khandanam

Now that we have seen the stories of the Purva-Acharyas, next, we shall know the story of Swami Ramanujar in sixteen short segments.

11.2.1 Birth of Swami Ramanujar



Ramanujar is regarded as the greatest theologian of the Srivaishnava Lineage Sampradayam, which is one of the two theistic Schools of Vedanta following the philosophy of Visishtadvaita — the other being the Dvaita system. The Srivaishnava Sampradayam arose in the Tamizh region of South India, and as a tradition, had its origin with twelve mystics known as the Azhwars. These Azhwars composed hymns in Tamizh expressing their love and devotion to God, particularly in the form of Sri Krishna. According to modern scholarship, they lived from about the 2nd to the 8th-century CE., but ancient tradition ascribes to them a period from 430 BCE downwards. Their lives and compositions encompassed all forms of intense love for the Lord. This

devotional approach has been categorized in later times by Chaitanya Mahaprabhu with attitudes known as Dasya, Apatya, Sakhya, Vatsalya, and Madhurya.

Swami Ramanujar was the only child of a learned Yajur Veda Brahmana named Asuri Kesava Dikshitar and his wife, Kantimati. Kesava Dikshitar was known by the title of Sarvakratu, meaning the performer of all Vedic sacrifices, by way of recognition of his expertise in Vedic rituals. He lived in the village of Sriperumbudur, which is situated about 30 miles to the southwest of the modern city of Chennai. This village is famous for its magnificent temple of Sri Adikeshava Perumal. Keshava Dikshitar had no children even after several years of marriage. Finally, he decided to seek the grace of the Lord Parthasarathy, residing at Tiruvallikeni. Lord Sri Krishna appeared to him in a dream and said he was impressed with the devotion and steadfast observance of dharma that Keshava Dikshitar followed. He then told Keshava Dikshitar that He would reincarnate as his son to establish order in the times of Kali Yuga, which was dominated by adharma. He said that the son that would be born would become a great Acharya who would be revered by all for time immemorial.

Accordingly, a year later, in 1017 in the Chaitra month under the Tiruadra nakshatram.

Kantimati gave birth to a son with the auspicious marks of Vishnu on his body; he was named Ramanuja, which was the name of Lakshmana, the younger brother of Sri Rama. Lakshmana was considered to be the incarnation of a part of Vishnu called Adishesha, who is the foremost servant of the Lord in Sri Vaikuntham.

11.2.2 Education under Yadava Prakashar

When Swami Ramanujar was very young, Swami Ramanujar had got his upanayanam done. His father, Keshava Dikshitar, attained paramapadam; thus, Swami Ramanujar had to perform his last rites at a very young age. He had not received any formal education and wanted to understand the meaning of the mantras that were being recited. After all the ceremonies were completed, Swami Ramanujar started to receive education from Yadava Prakashar, who was the foremost Advaita guru at the time. Yadava Prakashar's gurukulam was situated in Tiruputkuzhi, which lies outside Kanchipuram. Swami Ramanujar used to walk 40 km every day from Sri Perembudur to Kanchipuram to receive an education. One day in one of the lectures on the Upanishads, the Upanishad Vaakyam stating "**Satyam, Jnanam, Anantham Brahma**" is said to have been uttered by Yadava Prakashar. It was at this point one of Swami Ramanujar's classmates asked Yadav Prakashar to further give clarity on the Upanishad Vaakyam. Thus Yadava Prakashar tells the class that "**Satyatvam, Jnanatvam, Ananthatvam** are individual characteristics similar to that of the horns of a cow. The horns of a cow can be categorized as **Khandatva, Mundatva, Poornashringatvam**. According to Advaita philosophy, a man can see that a cow has no horns, half a horn, or it has a complete horn. But all three conditions cannot exist at the same time. Similarly, the Lord cannot possess all three qualities at the same time. Thus the Lord is termed as **Nirguna Brahma** ." It is then that Swami Ramanujar poses a question to Yadava Prakashar, saying if I, a student can sit, can breathe, can listen and question you all at once, why cannot the Lord possess Satyatvam,

Jnanatvam, and Anathatvam all at once? Yadava Prakashar was silenced by the question and felt very insulted. Thus he called off the rest of the lesson for the day. The following day Swami Ramanujar did not attend classes as his mother was not keeping well. The following day, when Swami Ramanujar went to the gurukulam, the students were talking amongst themselves that they had to perform kinkaryam to their Acharya in the form of massaging their Acharya's head. Swami Ramanujar volunteered to apply oil and massage his Acharya's head. As Swami Ramanujar was massaging his Acharya's head, a student asked a doubt to the Acharya. The student asked the Acharya to repeat the previous day's lesson, which was another Upanishad Vaakyam from the Chandogya Upanishad that says " **tasya yatha kapyasam pundarikam evam akshini.** " This verse describes how the Lord's divine eyes appear. Yadava Prakashar begins his explanation by giving an exact translation of the verse by saying His eyes are like that of the posterior of a monkey. Swami Ramanujar felt so insulted that he started weeping when he heard this type of comparison being made. Swami Ramanujar then said that this comparison being made is very wrong. The word **kapyasam** in Sanskrit grammar has many meanings. One can be interpreted as the posterior of a monkey. Another interpretation is that of the thin disk of light that envelopes the sun during sunrise. Another interpretation is something that is blown up and out of proportion. When Swami Ramanujar gives these three explanations, he says none of these explanations can be used to describe the eyes of the Lord. Yadava Prakashar gets furious and tells Ramanujar to come to the point and give a so-called befitting explanation that would be better than Adi Shankaracharya's commentary, which says the Lord's eyes looks like the posterior of a monkey.

Swami Ramanujar describes that the word kapi: in Sanskrit refers to the sun. The word **kapyasam** refers to kapyā: aayasam, which can be described in the following scenario. Imagine a pond with still freshwater, which has lotus flowers blooming in it. When the rays of the sun fall on the surface of the pond, the water evaporates, causing the lotus to bloom with all its resplendence. Thus the eyes of the Lord can be described as that which is equivalent to that of the sun and possesses a gaze that is as soft as the petals of the lotus. All the students started to praise Swami Ramanujar, and this insulted Yadava Prakashar for the second time. Yadava Prakashar felt so insulted that he decided to kill Swami Ramanujar as he realized that he would become a great personality in the future if nothing were done. Thus, Yadava Prakashar planned a field trip to Kashi. On the way somewhere in the vicinity of the Vindya Hills, he told the rest of the students that the next morning when they would bathe in the river, one student should push Ramanujar's head, and one must push Ramanujar's back so that he would drown. Among the students that were present was Swami Ramanujar's cousin Govindan. Govindan could not bear to let his cousin die. Thus, in the middle of the night, he woke Ramanujar from his sleep and told him Yadava Prakashar's plans. He then asked him to run away, or he would lose his life. Thus Ramanujar is said to have started running and reached some forests in modern-day Maharashtra. Swami Ramanujar started to look around and realized he was lost beyond any possible help. It was then that he thought that he had to reach Kanchipuram somehow as he knew the way home from there. Then a hunter-huntress couple is said to have come and told Swami Ramanujar that they were coming from Sidhashramam, which is situated in Uttar Pradesh, and said they were

traveling towards South India. They decided that they would travel together in the morning and slept. In the morning, when Swami Ramanujar awoke from his sleep, he saw the couple had fled and a group of Vaishnavas and asked them how he could get to Kanchipuram. The Vaishnavas laughed at him and asked him to look ahead, and he would see the gopuram of Varadaraja Perumal Kovil. Swami Ramanujar went to the temple and had darshanam of Sri Varadaraja Perumal and Sri Perundevi Thayaar. When Swami Ramanujar saw Varadaraja Perumal, he saw a close resemblance to the hunter, and when he saw Perundevi Thayaar, he saw a close resemblance to the huntress. Thus he concluded that the hunter and huntress were none other than Varadaraja Perumal and Perundevi Thayaar, who had come to rescue him from the forest during the night.

11.2.3 Swami Ramanujar in Kanchipuram

After being saved by Sri Varadaraja Perumal and Perundevi, Thayaar Ramanujar stayed back in Kanchipuram, performing kainkaryam to Varadaraja Perumal. In a few months, Yadava Prakashar started the journey back to Kanchipuram. On the way back, he and his entourage made a stop at Kalahasti. Here Yadava Prakashar was impressed with Govindan and told him that he should no longer be a Vaishnava and applied vibuthi on his forehead. Yadava Prakashar then placed a rudraksha-mala on Govindan's neck and renamed him Ulangai Kulindha Naayanaar. He left Govindan there to perform puja and kainkaryam to Lord Shiva.

Upon reaching Kanchipuram, Yadava Prakashar realized that Swami Ramanujar was still alive and well. He also noticed that he seemed oblivious to his plan to kill Swami

Ramanujar. Yadava Prakashar then went to Swami Ramanujar and invited him to be his student again. Swami Ramanujar obliged and went back to Yadava Prakashar's gurukulam. The daily routine continued for Swami Ramanujar, who fell under the tutelage of Yadava Prakashar. At around this time, Aalavandaar was visiting Kanchipuram in search of a future propagator for the Sri Vaishnava philosophy. One day when Yadava Prakashar and his students were taking a trip to Kanchipuram, Aalavandaar's gaze caught a glimpse of Swami Ramanujar. He asked his pupils who that person was. They told Aalavandaar of all the exploits they had heard of Swami Ramanujar and how he had dared to give a new commentary to the various Upanishad Vaakyams. It was then that Aalavandaar decided that Swami Ramanujar would become the future torch bearer to propagate Sri Vaishnava Philosophy.

Soon in another Upanishad lecture, there arose a controversy between Swami Ramunujar and Yadava Prakashar. It was at this time a royal guard from the king's court approached Yadava Prakashar. The imperial guard brought news that the local princess had become the victim of a Brahma-rakshsas and that the king had requested Yadava Prakashar to appear before the royal court to break brahma-rakshsas' hold over the princess. Yadava Prakashar thought it was a waste of his time and told the guard to inform the brahma-rakshsas that Yadava Prakashar had commanded the brahma-rakshsas to release the princess at once. When the guard approached the brahma-rakshsas, it mocked Yadava Prakashar and said it would not leave until the old fool would come in person and try his hand at trying to release it from the princess. The next day, Yadava Prakashar, along with his student group, went to the royal palace to assess the situation and release the brahma-rakshsas. Yadava Prakashar was placed face-to-face with the possessed princess and was asked to help her. Yadava

Prakashar, in pride, spoke to the brahma-rakshsas. He told the brahma-rakshsas that he was the great Advaita Sanyasi Yadava Prakashar, and he commanded the brahma-rakshsas to release the princess. The brahma-rakshsas started cackling and told Yadava Prakashar that it remembered everything about its previous life and also knew everything about Yadava Prakashar's past life. It said to Yadava Prakashar that in his earlier life, he was a peasant who would eat out of others' leftover plates. It then said once when he was living in Maduranthakam, he had the opportunity to eat a single grain out of rice out of a Vaishanva's plate, which gave him the punyam to be reborn as an Advaita Sanyasi in this life. It further said in its previous life, it was a brahmin who was well versed in the Vedas. It was brought into this form as it had once made an error in the shruthi while chanting the Vedas. It then said Yadava Prakashar was in no way qualified to be a teacher, and it would not leave the princess on his instruction. Yadava Prakashar felt brutally insulted. He asked a final question to the brahma-rakshsas. He asked on whose command it would free the princess. The brahma-rakshsas laughed and asked him to look behind him to his pupil, who would dare to defy him. There was only one student who had ever challenged his saying. In complete embarrassment, Yadava Prakashar called Ramanujar to release the brahma-rakshsas. Swami Ramanujar approached the princess and gently told the brahma-rakshsas to leave the princess' body and pointed out to a tree from the window. He told the brahma-rakshsas to break a branch of that tree and to be relieved of its current state. The brahma-rakshsas immediately left as commanded, and Swami Ramanujar's fame started to grow once again.

11.2.4 Ramanujar's Journey to Sri Rangam

After the miracle performed by Swami Ramanujar at the king's court, he gained an unbelievable amount of fame among the masses. This caused Yadava Prakashar's jealousy to stir up even further. This caused Swami Ramanujar's mother to get worried. She told Swami Ramanjar that his guru was not showing the ideal characters of a teacher as he was getting jealous of his students' achievements and Swami Ramanujar to withdraw from Yadava Prakashar's gurukulam. Thus, Swami Ramanujar stopped attending his lessons at the gurukulam. At this same time, Aalavandaar, who was residing in Sri Rangam, wished to see Swami Ramanujar so that he could take him under his wing as a disciple. To make this a certainty, Periyambadi, who was one of Aalavandaar's foremost disciples, was sent to receive Swami Ramanujar from Kanchipuram. Thus, Periyambadi rushed to Kanchipuram and found Swami Ramanujar performing kankaryam to Sri Varadaraja Perumal in the form of getting water from a well for the Lord. Periyambadi went to Swami Ramanujar and told him the wish of his Acharya, who wished to take Swami Ramanujar under his tutelage. Swami Ramanujar was elated by the news and chose to travel to Sri Rangam to become Aalavandaar's disciple. Upon reaching Sri Rangam, sad news reaches the ears of Swami Ramanujar, saying Aalavandaar had attained Paramapadam. According to Guru Parampara, we cannot treat Paramapadam here as death but as a state of coma. The reason for which we will discuss further. When Swami Ramanujar went to see Aalavandaar's mortal remains, he noticed that Aalavandaar's right hand was holding up three fingers. When Swami Ramanujar asked the fellow disciples why he was holding out three fingers, they said those three fingers represent Aalavandaar's

final wishes that he wished Swami Ramanujar to carry out. The three requests are as follows:

1. To write a commentary of the Vedanta Sutras that were written by Maharishi Vedavyasa, revealing its knowledge to the commoner.
2. To honor Maharishi Vedavyasa, who wrote the Mahabharata, and Maharishi Parashara, who wrote the Vishnu Puranam by naming two capable people with their names.
3. To propagate the Visishta Advaita Philosophy, name a person after Namazhwar and get them to write a commentary for the Tiruvaimozhi.

As Swami Ramanujar vowed to satisfy each of these three wishes, Aalavandaar's three fingers closed into his palm, and a sense of satisfaction was visible on his face. Thus we can infer that Aalavandaar was in a state of coma and had not yet attained Paramapadam. After Swami Ramanujar took these three vows, Aalavandaar truly attained Paramapadam.

11.2.5 Encounter with Tirukacchi Nambigal

We have seen the three vows taken by Swami Ramanujar at the mortal remains of Aalavandaar at Sri Rangam. After returning to Kanchipuram, Swami Ramanujar got married to a woman named Rakshambal. At the age of 28, Swami Ramanujar's mother attained Paramapadam. After his mother attained Paramapadam, Swami Ramanujar continued his education under the disciples of Aalavandaar and continued performing kainkaryam to Sri Varadaraja Perumal at Kanchipuram. At Kanchipuram, Swami Ramanujar first met Tirukacchi Nambigal, who was another disciple of Aalavandaar. Although Tirukacchi Nambigal was not a brahmin, he was treated with immense

respect because of his simple-minded and broad-minded approach. Tirukacchi Nambigal was allowed to perform ***chamara*** seva to Sri Varadaraja Perumal. It is said that Varadaraja Perumal used to converse with Tirukacchi Nambigal during the time in which he used to perform ***chamara*** seva. Swami Ramanujar was anxious to meet Tirukacchi Nambigal. When Swami Ramanujar first met Tirukacchi Nambi, he invited Tirukacchi Nambigal to come over to his house for a meal. Swami Ramanujar's house was situated in the periphery of the Varadaraja Perumal Temple, which is humungous. Tirukacchi Nambigal accepted the invite and told Swami Ramanujar that he would love to come to his place for a meal. He said he would enter the following day for lunch. The next day near lunchtime, Swami Ramanujar was anxiously awaiting the arrival of Tirukacchi Nambigal. As he was very anxious, he told his wife Rakshambal that he would go and check on where their guest was situated and left the house. Soon Tirukacchi Nambigal arrived at Swami Ramanujar's house. Rakshambal was a very narrow-minded woman. She knew that Tirukacchi Nambigal was not a brahmin. Hence she asked him to sit outside the house's central courtyard. She then asked him if he had anything to eat. He replied that he had come to their home as Swami Ramanujar invited him for lunch. She then spread out a banana leaf in the outer courtyard and served his meal very scantily. Tirukacchi Nambigal thanked her for the meal and left. As soon as Tirukacchi Nambigal had left the house, Rakshambal pushed the banana leaf with a stick, cleaned the area with cow dung, broke the earthen vessels in which she had prepared meals for Tirukacchi Nambigal, and took a bath to cleanse herself. When Swami Ramanujar returned, he noticed that Rakshambal's hair was untied and was wet. He asked if Tirukacchi Nambigal had come to the house. Rakshambal, with a disgusted face, tells Swami Ramanujar that the vaishya had come and she had served him food. She was disgusted by the fact that her

husband wanted to engage himself with the likes of a lower caste man. Swami Ramanujar felt insulted by her behavior but did not speak up as he did not wish to insight violence inside the household. A few days passed by, and Swami Ramanujar ran into Tirukacchi Nambigal inside the temple, and with folded hands, he pleaded for forgiveness for his wife's actions. He told Tirukacchi Nambigal that he had some questions about his dharmam that he would like to talk about with him. Tirukacchi Nambigal said he was on his way to perform **chamara** seva to Varadaraja Perumal and told Swami Ramanujar he would ask the Lord as He is all-knowing. As Tiukacchi Nambigal waved the **chamaram** to the Lord, the Lord sensed a longing emanating from Tirukacchi Nambigal and asked him if he had any questions to ask Him. Tirukacchi Nambigal told the Lord that the questions were not his but those of Swami Ramanujar. Varadaraja Perumal is then supposed to have told Tirukacchi Nambigal 6 statements as follows:

1. Ahameva Paramtatvam
2. Darshanam bedameva cha
3. Upayeshu Prapatti syaath
4. Anthima Smrithi Varjanam
5. Dehaa Vasaane Mukti Syaath
6. Purnacharya Samashrayaha

These six statements can be interpreted in the following way:

1. Ahameva Paratatvam: The Lord is the ultimate truth, and He is all-knowing.

2. Darshanam Bedameva cha: This statement is interpreted by the statement of "***Tat Tvam Asi.*** " The jeevaathma is always independent of the Paramaathma but longs to reach the Paramaathma.
3. Upayeshu Prapatti Syaath: To be truly free from the cycle of life and death, one must perform Prapatti to the Lord at the hands of an Acharya.
4. Anthima Smrithi Varjanam: According to shastras, one will genuinely attain moksham when they remember the Lord at the time before the jeevaathma leaves the mortal body. As it is difficult for everyone to remember the Lord during Kaliyugam, the Lord tells Tirukacchi Nambi that He would remember those on the deathbed if they had performed Prapatti during their lifetime.
5. Dehaa Vasaane Mukthi Syaath: After death, the soul is weighed to see if it is fit to attain moksham. If the jeevaathma in its lifetime had performed Prapatti, it would gain direct access into Vaikuntham to eternally thrive in the presence of the Lord.
6. Purnacharya Samashrayaha: Taking refuge at the feet of an Acharya and getting panchasamskaaram done by his hands is the means to Prapatti.

After his conversation with Varadaraja Perumal, Tirukacchi Nambigal tells Swami Ramanujar of his conversation with the Lord and tells Swami Ramanujar the six statements that were said by the Lord. Swami Ramanujar immediately rushes to meet Periya Nambi at Sri Rangam. At the same time, Ranganatha Perumal instructs Periya Nambi to perform panchasamskaaram to Swami Ramanujar. The two meet at Maduranthakam's Yeri Kaatha Raamar Perumal temple, where Periya Nambi performed panchasamskaaram to Swami Ramanujar and initiated him into Sri Vaishnava Parampara.

11.2.6 Swami Ramanujar's takes up Sanyasam

After getting panchasamskaaram done at the hands of Periya Nambi, Swami Ramanujar invites Periya Nambi to his house. Swami Ramanujar feels he could gain and learn a lot from an Acharya living under the same roof. Swami Ramanujar tells Periya Nambi that his house was partitioned into the ground and first floors. Swami Ramanujar tells Periya Nambi that he and his wife would occupy the ground floor, and Periya Nambi could move into the first floor. Periya Nambi agreed to Swami Ramanujar's arrangement and moved into Swami Ramanujar's house in Kanchipuram. Under Periya Nambi's tutelage, Swami Ramanujar learned about the Naalayira Divyaprabandhangal, except for the part of Tiruvaimozhi, he learned the various Brahmasutrams with their meaning to become capable of writing a commentary for them. He also learned about the contributions of all the Purvaacharyas.

One day, a poor Vaishnava came to Swami Ramanujar's doorstep seeking alms. The poor man called out from the door, and Rakshambal came out to answer before Swami Ramanujar. When the elderly man asked for some food, Rakshambal immediately said there was no food left in the kitchen. The poor man left the house hungry and empty-handed. Swami Ramanujar immediately rushed into the kitchen and saw that there was still food that was left in the pots. He questioned Rakshambal as to why she sent the poor man away empty-handed. She told Swami Ramanujar that the man might have been a Vaishnava, but he had been roaming the streets for food. He might have come in contact with other caste men. Hence she refused to feed him. Swami Ramanujar again felt insulted but stayed silent for the second time.

In a few days, Swami Ramanujar had gone to the Varadaraja Perumal Temple as he usually would and performed kainkaryam to Varadaraja Perumal. In the time that Swami Ramanujar was at the temple, Periya Nambi and his wife packed all their belongings and left to go back to Sri Rangam. They thanked Rakshambal and told her that they were returning to Sri Rangam. When Swami Ramanujar returned home, he noticed that his Acharya and his Acharya-Patni were not at home. He immediately enquired with Rakshambal as to where they had gone. Rakshambal told Swami Ramanujar that they had left the house and went back to Sri Rangam. Swami Ramanujar asked why they did that. Rakshambal tells Swami Ramanujar that she had gotten into a big argument with Periya Nambi's wife in the morning. She told Swami Ramanujar that as they were getting water from the well in the morning, a few drops of water from Periya Nambi's wife pot had dripped into her pot. Getting angry, Rakshambal had called Periya Nambi's wife a blind hag who did not know the difference in caste between their families. After saying this, Rakshambal casually mentioned that she was glad that they had left the household. This last incident was more than Swami Ramanujar could handle. He wrote out all of his wealth in her name and told her that he had received a message from her father that they wanted Rakshambal to come home as her younger sister's marriage was soon approaching. As soon as Rakshambal had left to her parents' house, Swami Ramanujar immediately changed out his current wear and took upon ***kaashaayam***, which is the saffron-colored wear of a sanyasi. He then went to Sri Varadaraja Perumal, held the ***tridhandam***, and asked the Lord to grant him sanyasaashramam. Through the guidance of Tirukacchi Nambi, Varadaraja Perumal gave Swami Ramanujar the title of ***Yathiraja***.

11.2.7 Gaining of Disciples

After taking up sanyasaashramam, Swami Ramanujar's fame and popularity further grew. Swami Ramanujar started to gain many followers and disciples. Among the first disciples were Swami Ramanujar's Purvaasharama first cousin Dasharathi and another young man named Kuresha (Kurathalwan). Kurathalwan came from a very wealthy household. Hundreds of people would throng to Kurathalwan's doorstep seeking alms, clothing, and vessels that Kurathalwan would give without any second thought. When Kurathalwan met Swami Ramanujar, he decided to give up all his wealth and stay by the side of his acharyan to perform kinkaryam. Kurathalwan and his wife Andal-amma gave away all of their wealth and, by sunset, left their house for Sri Rangam to be by the side of Swami Ramanujar. As they were going through the forest, Andal-amma started to show signs of fear. Kurathalwan sensed that his wife was still holding on to some wealth and asked her what she had brought along with her. Andal-amma tells Kurathalwan that she had kept one golden cup in her possession just in case Kurathalwan wanted to drink water along the way. Kurathalwan immediately took the golden cup and flung it away, telling her the only wealth they were to possess was the wealth of knowledge that Swami Ramanujar would preach to them. Thus Kurathalwan and his wife reached Sri Rangam to be under Swami Ramanujar. In the meanwhile, Yadava Prakashar's gurukulam had closed due to the lack of students. Yadava Prakashar spent his days in remorse and torment, thinking of how he felt he was superior. It was then that Yadava Prakashar's mother told him to go and seek refuge at the feet

of Swami Ramanujar. Thus Yadava Prakashar leaves for Sri Rangam and falls at the feet of Swami Ramanujar and asks him for an opportunity to be a changed individual. Swami Ramanujar whole-heartedly obliges and performs panchasamskaaram to Yadava Prakashar, thereby converting him into a Vaishnava, giving him the name of Govinda Yati.

11.2.8 Meeting with Tirukkotiur Nambigal

After reforming his former teacher Yadava Prakashar to Vaishnavism and giving him the name of Govinda Yati, Swami Ramanujar remembered his cousin Govindan who had saved his life years ago. Govinda Yati tells Swami Ramanujar that his cousin was now known as Ulangai Kulindha Naayanaar and was serving Lord Shiva as an Advaiti at Kalahasti. Ulangai Kulindha Naayanaar used to serve Lord Shiva, who was in the form of Bana Lingam. He used to apply sandalwood paste to the lingam, perform pushpa-kainkaryam, and perform aaradhanam to Lord Shiva. At Swami Ramanujar's request, Sri Saila Purna, who was Swami Ramanujar's uncle, reformed Ulangai Kulindha Naayanaar to Vaishnavism and gave him the name of Embaar. Embaar took his formal leave from Lord Shiva and went to Sri Rangam to stay by the side of Swami Ramanujar.

Soon a time came when Swami Ramanujar wished to learn the three rahasyams or secrets of Sri Vaishnava Philosophy which are :

1. Tirumantram or the Asthaaksharam.
2. The Dwaya Mantram.
3. The Charama Shloka.

Swami Ramanujar traveled to Tirukkotiur to meet Tirukkotiur Nambigal to learn the rahasyams. When Swami Ramanujar arrived in Tirukkotiur, he first met Tirukkotiur Nambigal, who asked Swami Ramanujar to return the following day. Swami Ramanujar went back to Sri Rangam and returned the next day. When Swami Ramanujar met Tirukkotiur Nambigal the next morning, he again requested Swami Ramanujar to return the next day. Tirukkotiur Nambigal repeated the same exercise seventeen times.

Each of the seventeen times Swami Ramanujar was sent back were an indication of a real student to return after he had gained or overcome the following to gain knowledge of the rahasyams :

1. **Samsara Bijam Tholaindha pin Varum:** A student must be bereft of worldly desires.
2. **Ahankaram, Mamakaram Tholaindha pin Varum:** A student must not possess any kind of arrogance, ego, and self-centered attitude.
3. **Aathma Gnanam Kidaitha pin Varum:** A student must possess the knowledge of behavior and nature of the aathma.
4. **Dehaathmabhimanan Tholaindha pin Varum:** Lose the impression that the body and asthma are the same.
5. **Aishwarya, Aamushmiga, Kaivalyathigalil moham vittu Varum:** Lose the attitude of wanting to cheat anyone for money.
6. **Vishayantaratil Patru vitta pin Varum:** Lose the attitude of seeking a second opinion concerning the Lord and His Bhagvath Vishayam.
7. **Bhagavadh Vishayatil ruchhi pirantha pin Varum:** Find a sense of love in the Lord and His Bhagavth Vishayam.

8. **Raga-Dveshathikal Tholaindha pin Varum:** Realize the actions committed in anger and desire have repercussions and act accordingly.
9. **Para thantriya unarva pirandha pin Varum:** Realize that we are dependent on the Lord to live.
10. **Sri Vaishnavatvam kai kudiya pin Varum:** Realize the meaning of compassion(Sri Vaishnavathvam).
11. **Sathvika parikgraham kidaitha pin Varum:** Learn to realize and enjoy the nature of Sattva Gunam.
12. **Bhagavatha parikgraham kidaitha pin Varum:** Learn to converse with a Bhagavatha at the first meeting.
13. **Bhagavath parikgraham kidaitha pin Varum:** Learn upon seeing the Lord that our thoughts must not waver, and our thoughts must solely be focused on Him through immense bhakti.
14. **Ananya-Seshatvam-Upayatvam kidaitha pin Varum:** Learn that we as human beings are all equals, and if there is anyone that we cannot equate ourselves to, that is the Lord.
15. **Ananya Prayojanatvam kidaitha pin Varum:** Learn that the greatest boon that the Lord offers us is moksham, and we must accept it with open arms without the desire for anything else.
16. **Ananya Bhogyatvam kidaitha pin Varum:** Learn that performing sharanagathi beyond all the difficulties of our life will see us through to safety and ensure the Lord's grace upon us.
17. **Acharyan kidaitha pin Varum:** A student must find a capable Acharya who can guide and teach him all of the above.

18. Tirumantra Artham kai koodum: When one satisfies all of the above is when the Tirumantram, Dwayam, and Charama Shlokams come into effect in one's life.

When Swami Ramanujar returned to Tirukkotiur Nambigal for the eighteenth time, he told Swami Ramanujar the eighteen reasons. He said to him that he did not doubt in his mind that Swami Ramanujar possessed the above qualities. Still, he conducted this exercise as this was how Swami Ramanujar was to test his disciples before giving them the knowledge of the three great secrets. Tirukkotiur Nambigal agrees to give Swami Ramanujar the insight of the rahasyams and calls him to enter a room. As Swami Ramanujar came, Tirukkotiur Nambigal noticed that with Swami Ramanujar came Nadathoor Azhwan, Embaar, and Modhali Aandaan, who were Swami Ramanujar's foremost disciples. Tirukkotiur Nambigal questions Swami Ramanujar as to how his disciples entered the room along with him. Swami Ramanujar then tells Tirukkotiur Nambigal that the three of them are like the tridandam he holds and the pavithram he wears. They are inseparable for a sanyasi.

Similarly, his three disciples are inseparable from him. They had made the same journey as Swami Ramannujar had made over the past seventeen days, and they were worthy of receiving the rahasyams. Tirukkotiur Nambigal agreed with Swami Ramanujar and gave them the three rahasyams and their meaning. The meaning of the three rahasyams are as follows:

Ashtaaksharam: This mantram consists of the Pranavam, followed by Namō Narayanaya. The mantra and meaning for which can be found in the Vedas and interpreted in the following way :

ओमित्ये॒व व्या॒हरेत्। नम॑ इति॒ प॒श्चात्। ना॒रा॒य॒णा॒येत्यु॑परि॒ष्ठात्। ओमित्ये॒-
का॒क्षर॑म्। नम॑ इति॒ द्वे अ॒क्षरे॑। ना॒रा॒य॒णा॒येति॑ पञ्चौ॒क्षरा॑णि। ए॒तद्वै ना॒रा॒य॒णस्या॑ष्टाक्ष॒रं
प॒दम्। यो ह॑ वै ना॒रा॒य॒णस्या॑ष्टाक्ष॒रं प॒दम॑ध्येति॒। अन॑प॒ब्र॒वस्सर्व॑मा॒यूरे॑ति॒। वि॒न्दते
प्रा॑जाप॒त्यं रा॒यस्यो॑षं गौ॒प॒त्यम्। ततो॑ऽमृत॒त्वम॑श्नुते॒ ततो॑ऽमृत॒त्वम॑श्नु॒त इति॑। य
ए॒वं वे॒द॥

The meaning of the mantram can be understood in the following way. Pranavam is split into a-u-m. Where a-kaaram represents Bhagavan Mahavishnu, m-kaaram represents the jeevaathma, and u-kaaram represents Mahalakshmi. Thus after uttering the Pranavam, when Namaha is said, one must have the feeling of no self-centeredness and a sense of total unconditional surrender. Finally, while speaking the Lord's name Narayana, the person must whole-heartedly think of the path of reaching Him. Thus the Tirumantram can be understood as the way to Sharanagati.

Dwaya Mantram: This mantram consists of two halves. The first half acts as a means to ask the Lord and Mahalakshmi to accept our Sharanagati. The second half serves as a means to ask the Lord and Mahalakshmi to shower their grace upon us constantly.

Charama Shloka: This shloka is the means to Prapatti as given by Lord Krishna to Arjuna, wherein Lord Krishna tells Arjuna that He is the Ultimate Truth. He tells Arjuna to surrender and put all of his faith solely in Him, and he would relieve him from the cycle of birth and death and offer moksham.



Sarva dharmaan parityajya maam ekam sharaNam vraja ।

Aham tvaam sarva paapebhyo mokshayishyaami maa shucahaa ॥

सर्वधर्मान् परित्यज्य मामेकं शरणं व्रज ।

अहम् त्वां सर्वपापेभ्यो मोक्षयिष्यामि मा शुचः ॥ ८ ॥

Tirukkotiyyur Nambigal explains the rahasyams and their meanings to Swami Ramanujar and tells him that he is to propagate this knowledge only to disciples who possess the eighteen qualities that he had previously informed Swami Ramanujar about. Swami Ramanujar steps out of the closed quarters of Tirukkotiyyur Nambigal and briefly thinks for a while, and decides that he must do something before leaving Tirukkotiyyur. Swami Ramanujar races up to the top of Ashtanga Vimanam of the Sowmya Narayana Perumal Temple and tells everyone who wished to listen that if they wanted to be relieved from the cycle of life and death, they had to perform Sharanagati through an Acharya. A few people who heard Swami Ramanujar asked him what the means of obtaining this divine gift was. Swami Ramanujar told them to seek his refuge, and he would perform panchasamskaaram and reveal the heavenly secrets to achieve moksham. After saying this, he started to descend from the Vimanam. In this brief moment that Swami Ramanujar was descending from the Vimanam, word reached Tirukkotiyyur Nambigal of what Swami Ramanujar had done in revealing the divine secrets to the general public. Tirukkotiyyur Nambigal, in a fury,

rushed to the temple and confronted Swami Ramanujar, saying he had betrayed his guru by revealing the divine secrets. As punishment, he would undoubtedly go to hell for treason. Swami Ramanujar prostrated his guru and told Tirukkotiur Nambigal that he was more than ready to go to hell if he could provide the means to go to Vaikuntham for so many people.

11.2.9 Swami Ramanujar in Sri Rangam

After learning the three divine rahasyams from Tirukkotiur Nambi, Swami Ramanujar, along with his disciples, returned to Sri Rangam. Upon returning to Sri Rangam, Swami Ramanujar starts to preach and propagate all that he has learned thus far. In the meanwhile, he leaves Kurathalwan and Modhali Aandaan with Tirukkotiur Nambi to learn the meaning of the Charama Shloka and asks them to come back and teach. Soon he started work on a magnum opus known as Sri Bhashyam. During the compilation of Sri Bhashyam, Swami Ramanujar would dictate the shlokas and their commentary while Kurathalwan would sit and write down whatever Swami Ramanujar would say. Once while compiling the Sri Bhashyam, a question arose as to which character of a given jeevaathma would be its prime characteristic? Would it be Jnatritvam or Seshatvam? Jnatritvam refers to aathma expressing dharma jnanam whereas, Seshatvam refers to the aathma expressing that it is below the Lord and is dependant on Him for its existence. Swami Ramanujar claimed that Jnatritvam should be the character mentioned whereas, Kurathalwan claims that Seshatvam should be the quality specified. Swami Ramanujar says this argument could only be solved by Tirukkotiur Nambi and sends Kurathalwan to ask him which character should be

mentioned. Kurathalwan went to Tirukotiyur to ask Tiukkotiyur Nambi the question of debate. According to shastras, one must not request an Acharya a question until they give the student the authority to do so. Thus Kurathalwan went to Tiukkotiyur Nambi's house and started to perform kainkaryam to the Acharya. Soon two days passed. Five days passed. A fortnight passed. Fortnight became a month. One month became three months, and this finally became six months. Kurathalwan could not bear being separated from Swami Ramanujar any further. Kurathalwan says to Tiukkotiyur Nambi that he would take his leave. Tiukkotiyur Nambi senses that Kurathalwan had come with a question and tells him as he is about to leave, "Adiyan Ullana Pashuram Marandhadho?". Hearing this, Kurathalwan understands what Tiukkotiyur Nambi was trying to convey and, satisfied, goes to Swami Ramanujars' side at Sri Rangam. Upon arriving at Sri Rangam, Kurathalwan tells Swami Ramanujar that Seshatvam should be the character that should be mentioned. To substantiate, Kurathalwan tells Swami Ramanujar that Azhwars stated in their Pashurams that the Lord lives within us, and we are nothing but a mere vessel to Him. Hence Seshatvam should be the character mentioned.

As time passed, Swami Ramanujar sensed that changes had to be brought into the temple administration at Sri Rangam. Uttama Nambi, who was the temple administrator at the time, was against any type of change. He planned to kill Swami Ramanujar. One day when Swami Ramanujar was going around for alms, he came to the doorstep of Uttama Nambi, who called Swami Ramanujar inside and seated him. Before serving Swami Ramanujar food, Uttama Nambi laced the rice with poison. Uttama Nambi's wife sees what her husband does and tells him that it's wrong. Uttama Nambi threatens that he would slit her throat if she opened her mouth. Thus, to stop

Swami Ramanujar from eating the rice, she prostrates Swami Ramanujar and performs pradakshinam to Swami Ramanujar while the leaf with the food is placed before him. When anyone conducts this way before a sanyasi, it is the sanyasi's dharmam to reject the food and leave. Swami Ramanujar takes the leaf and throws it into the Kaveri River. Swami Ramanujar notices the fish in the river that ate the rice start plopping up and die a painful death. Swami Ramanujar understood that the rice was poisoned and that Uttama Nambi's wife conducted as she did to save him. Soon the news that Uttama Nambi tried to kill Swami Ramanujar started to spread like wildfire. Soon the news reached the ears of Tiukkotiyyur Nambi, who rushes to Sri Rangam to see Swami Ramanujar. When Swami Ramanujar found out that his Acharya was coming to Sri Rangam, he rushed to receive him. When Swami Ramanujar saw Tiukkotiyyur Nambi, he immediately started prostrating his Acharya. The sand on the banks of the river was scorching hot, and Swami Ramanujar continued to prostrate his Acharya. Soon a crowd gathered around the two great acharyas. The crowd notices that due to the heat, Swami Ramanujar was getting burned and was almost getting cooked to the bone. A man in the crowd speaks up and asks Swami Ramanujar to stop prostrating as the sight was unbearable. Once the man spoke up, Tiukkotiyyur Nambi asks Swami Ramanujar to stop prostrating and assigns that man to perform kitchen duties for Swami Ramanujar. He asks the man his name. The man replies that his name was Kidambi Achan. Tiukkotiyyur Nambi tells Kidambi Achan that his devotion was genuinely exceptional as he could not even bear the sight of Swami Ramanuajar going through pain. Tiukkotiyyur Nambi said that he would be one of Swami Ramanujar's most trusted aides. Swami Desikan comes in the lineage of Kidambi Achan on his maternal side.

11.2.10 Reforming Periya Kovil Nambi

Swami Ramanujar continued his stay in Sri Rangam and continued to try and gain access to the Rangantha Perumal temple keys to reform the way the temple was being administered. The temple keys were being held by a person named Periya Kovil Nambi. Periya Kovil Nambi was a man with a harsh temperament and was very stubborn. How much ever Swami Ramanujar tried to get the temple keys, Periya Kovil Nambi would avoid Swami Ramanujar. Before Periya Kovil Nambi became a respectable person who was in charge of temple administration, he was a gambler. Periya Kovil Nambi's mother came to Swami Ramanujar for help to reform her son's behavior. Swami Ramanujar went to the gambling house to observe Periya Kovil Nambi. After observing Periya Kovil Nambi's behavior, Swami Ramanujar sends Kurathalwan to get Periya Kovil Nambi from the gambling house to perform means of reform.

Kurathalwan taught Periya Kovil Nambi the shastras and various vyakyanams and turned the gambler into a respectable man who earned the right to control the temple administration. With time Periya Kovil Nambi started to gain a superiority complex over everyone as he had the sole right to control the temple and the way it was to run. In his opinion, he was above everyone except Ranganatha Perumal. Swami Ramanujar noticed that there were errors in the way he was conducting the temple rituals and hence deemed it necessary to gain access to the temple keys to change the way the temple was being administered. One day Periya Kovil Nambi was conducting a homam for which he required a learned acharya to be present for a position known as Ekaham. At the time, it was customary to go to Swami Ramanujar to grace such occasions. Thus, Periya Kovil Nambi came to Swami Ramanujar to grace the event.

Swami Ramanujar said he would send his guru Kurathalwan to grace the occasion. Periya Kovil Nambi was very happy to hear that his guru would grace the event. After the conduction of the homam, it was customary to give daanam to the person taking the position of Ekaham. The custom of providing daanam was to continue to keep giving until the person receiving the daanam would say they were satisfied. Thus, Periya Kovil Nambi started to give daanam to his guru, and after daanam, he would ask if he was satisfied. Kurathalwan would reply that he was not satisfied. Soon it came to a point where Periya Kovil Nambi asked his guru what it would take to earn his satisfaction. When this question was asked, Kurathalwan asked for the keys to the temple. Periya Kovil Nambi handed over the keys of the temple to Kurathalwan, who, in turn, handed them to Swami Ramanujar. Swami Ramanujar immediately took charge of all the temple activities. He established all the rituals that are practiced at the temple to date. When Periya Kovil Nambi noticed the changes, he realized that he was at fault. Swami Ramanujar then handed over the keys back to Periya Kovil Nambi. Periya Kovil Nambi promises to withhold the traditions as set up by Swami Ramanujar.

11.2.11 Ananthazhwan

After Swami Ramanujar brought about reform in the Sri Rangam temple, he was getting ready to take leave to Kanchipuram. He visited the lotus feet of Ranganatha Perumal to inform Him that he would be taking his leave. Ranganatha Perumal then told Swami Ramanujar to stay in Sri Rangam and make it his headquarters. Swami Ramanujar thus made Sri Rangam his headquarters.

At around the same time, there was a Hoysala king in Karnataka by the name of Bittideva, who was a Jain. His wife Shantala was a Vaishnava. She came to Sri Rangam to see Swami Ramanujar and asked him to reform her husband into Sri Vaishnavism. Thus Swami Ramanujar went to see Bittideva and converted him to Sri Vaishnavism. Bittideva then took the name of Vishnuvardhan and built the famous Channakeshava Temple at Belur.

Time passed, and Swami Ramanujar was looking for a troupe he could take along with him to Tirumala. Tirumala at the time was densely forested inhabited by many varieties of poisonous snakes and many wild animals. It was considered to be a journey once made that would send the person straight to Sri Vaikuntham as rarely one would return from making the journey up the hill. In such a situation, Swami Ramanujar held an open forum meeting with anyone whomsoever wished to listen to him. Swami Ramanujar asked in the forum as to who would make the journey with him to Tirumala. Only one person volunteered from the entire forum. This man was Ananthazhwan



Ananthazhwan

Ananthazhwan used to perform puspha-kanikaryam and theertha-kainkaryam to Sri Tiruvenkatamudaiyaan sincerely. Ananthazhwan had constructed a pushpa-brindavanam and named it after Swami Ramanujar. One day, he was constructing a tank for the temple with the help of his wife, who was expecting at the time. Ananthazhwan used to till the soil with the help of a crowbar, place the mud into a mud tray and give it to his wife, who used to put it on her head and dispose of the mud at a slightly far distance. One day when the same routine was running, a small boy approached Ananthazhwan's wife and told her that he would help her dispose of the mud without her husband noticing what was happening. Ananthazhwan's wife accepted the help. Soon Ananthazhwan saw the boy and chased after him, saying the work was being done in the name of the Lord, and he wanted nobody to help him. The boy seemed to run away but soon came back to assist Ananthazhwan's wife. When Ananthazhwan saw the boy again, he started to chase the boy again. The boy started

running and ran into the temple and soon inside the garbha griha. Seeing the boy run inside the garbha griha, Ananthazhwan threw his crowbar in the direction of the boy and soon noticed blood flowing out of the garbha griha. When he went to check on the boy, he noticed a scar on the chin of Lord Tiruvenkatamudaiyaan. He immediately realized that the boy was none other than the Lord Himself, who had come to assist Ananthazhwan in his work. Ananthazhwan is said to have cleaned the wound and applied camphor on the Lord's chin to give a soothing and cooling effect. The crowbar can still be seen in the temple to this day.



Ananthazhwan's Crowbar

11.2.12 Swami Ramanujar Reaches Tirupati

After Swami Ramanujar finished reforming the Ranganathar Temple at Sri Rangam, he decided to take a trip to Tirupati. When news of Swami Ramanujar reaching

Tirupati reached the ears of Periya Tirumalai Nambi (Swami Ramanujar's maternal uncle and Acharya) in Tirumala, he sent Ananthazhwan to go and bring Swami Ramanujar uphill. Ananthazhwan immediately went down to where Swami Ramanujar was staying in Tirupati and expressed Periya Tirumalai Nambi's wish and message. At first, Swami Ramanujar refused and said he could not reside on the hill as the hill was a personification of the Lord Himself. Ananthazhwan went back and told Periya Tirumalai Nambi that Swami Ramanujar had refused. The next morning, news reached Swami Ramanujar that Periya Tirumalai Nambi himself was on his way to meet him. Swami Ramanujar ran to meet Periya Tirumalai Nambi. As soon as Swami Ramanujar saw Periya Tirumalai Nambi, he immediately started to prostrate him. Periya Tirumalai Nambi asked Swami Ramanujar to stop prostrating him and gave him the laddoo prasadam of Sri Tiruvenkatamudaiyan. He then requested Swami Ramanujar to come and stay with him atop the hill. Swami Ramanujar agreed and went and stayed with Periya Tirumalai Nambi. During his first stay for three days, Swami Ramanujar neither ate nor drank water as that was the means not to excrete and impurify the hill. For the next year that followed, Swami Ramanujar stayed in Tirupati and learned the entirety of the Ramayanam from Periya Tirumalai Nambi. At the same time, he completed a magnum opus, which was a commentary to the Bhagavad Gita, which expresses the essence of all the Upanishads. He traveled to the top of the hill and presented this magnum opus at the holy lotus feet of Lord Tiruvenkatamudaiyan. This magnum opus is known as Vedaartha Sangrahaha.

After writing and giving Vedaartha Sangrahaha, Swami Ramanujar wrote another magnum opus known as Gita Bhashyam, which was a commentary on the Bhagavad Gita. He placed this also at the holy feet of Lord Tiruvenkatamudaiyan.

11.2.13 Swami Ramanujar's Digvijaya Yatra

After returning from Tirupati, Swami Ramanujar announced a *Digvijaya Yatra* in which he would tour the entire country on foot, visiting multiple kshethrams. Accompanying Swami Ramanujar on the journey were a few disciples, of which the most prominent was Kurathazhwan. Swami Ramanujar's first destination was Tirukkudandai. Here he first visited the Sarangapani Perumal Kovil. After visiting the temple, he had an intense philosophical debate with the Advaiti scholars at Kumbakonam and convinced them to become Sri Vaishnavas. The next destination in his yatra led him to Tirumaaliruncholai, where he visited the Kallazhagar Perumal Kovil. The next destination in his yatra led him to Tirupullani, where he visited the Kalyana Jagannatha Perumal Kovil and Darbhashayana Ramar Kovil and performed Setu Snanam. The next destination in his yatra led him to Azhwar Tirunagari. The next destination in his yatra led him to Tirukurungudi. Here Swami Ramanujar had a conversation with Tirukurungudi Nambi. The Lord tells Bhagawad Ramanujacharya that he has accomplished what He could not achieve in all His births. The Lord asks to be initiated into Sri Vaishnavism by Bhagawad Ramanujacharya. Bhagawad Ramanujacharya is said to have performed Pancha-Samskaaram for the Lord here, giving Him the name of Sri Vaishnava Nambi. The next destination in his yatra led him to Tiruvanparisaram, Tiruvattaru, and then Tiruvananthapuram. Then traveling north, Swami Ramanujar reached Dwaraka, where he went to see Lord Dwarikadeesh. Moving further north, Swami Ramanujar went to Gokulam, Mathura, Vrindavanam, and Govardhanam. Continuing north, Swami Ramanujar went to Muktinath, Badrinath, Joshi Mutt, Devaprayag, and then to Pushkaram. To finish his yatra, he went to Kashmir in search of the Saraswati Bhandaaram, a great library that held

many great books of Sanathana Dharma. Swami Ramanujar, along with Kurathazhwan, went to the Saraswathi Bhandaaram, which was holding the Vrithi Grantham written by Bodhayana. The Vrithi Grantham was a book that was a commentary to all the Brahmasutrams. Swami Ramanujar reached the Saraswathi Bhandaaram, which was being guarded by two pandits. The two pandits asked Swami Ramanujar why he had come to the library. When Swami Ramanujar told them that he wanted to take the Vrithi Grantham, the two pandits laughed and guided him and Kurathazhwan to an idol of Devi Saraswathi. The idol posed a riddle to Swami Ramanujar. The riddle was as follows " **tasya yatha kapyasam pundarikam evam akshini.** " Swami Ramanujar immediately gave a detailed answer as this was the very same statement that he had first given a commentary for under Yadava Prakashar's education. The word **kapyasam** in Sanskrit grammar has many meanings. One can be interpreted as the posterior of a monkey. Another interpretation is that of the thin disk of light that envelopes the sun during sunrise. Another interpretation is something that is blown up and out of proportion. When Swami Ramanujar gives these three explanations, he says none of these explanations can be used to describe the eyes of the Lord. Swami Ramanujar describes that the word kapi: in Sanskrit refers to the sun. The word **kapyasam** refers to kapyasam, which can be described in the following scenario. Imagine a pond with still freshwater, which has lotus flowers blooming in it. When the rays of the sun fall on the surface of the pond, the water evaporates, causing the lotus to bloom with all its resplendence. Thus the eyes of the Lord can be described as that which is equivalent to that of the sun and possesses a gaze that is as soft as the petals of the lotus. Saraswathi Devi tells Swami Ramanujar that she was impressed by his answer and that She would grant him access to her library and allow him to take the Vrithi Grantham. Thus Swami Ramanujar took the

Vrithi Grantham and started his journey back towards Sri Rangam. By night, Swami Ramanujar and Kurathazhwan reached Kashi and decided to spend the night there. Swami Ramanujar fell asleep, saying he was tired from the travel. Later in the morning, when both Swami Ramanujar and Kurathazhwan awoke from their sleep, they saw that the Vrithi Grantham was missing. Swami Ramanujar was heartbroken as he understood the pandits must have stolen the Grantham from them when they were sleeping. Kurathazhwan then tells his Acharya not to feel bad as he had read the entire Grantham in the night before falling asleep. He told his Acharya that his curiosity to know what was in the Grantham did not let him sleep; thus, he read every last word in the Grantham before sleeping. Swami Ramanujar decides to test Kurathazhwan and asks him to tell him whatever he could remember from the Grantham. Kurathazhwan recited the entire Grantham before Swami Ramanujar and told him that he could remember anything he read in a single attempt. Swami Ramanujar and Kurathazhwan returned to Sri Rangam. After returning to Sri Rangam, Swami Ramanujar started writing another magnum opus, which was a commentary to the Brahmasutrams written by Bhodhayana. Swami Ramanujar used the references of Azhwar Pashurams, Brahmasutra-Artham, taught to him by Tirukacchi Nambi and the Vrithi Grantham through Kurathazhwan to write the great *Sri Bhasyam*.

11.2.14 Kulothunga Chola and the migration to Melukote

Now we reach that stage of the story where Swami Ramanujar is reaching his mid-to-late fifties in age. At around this time, Kulothunga Chola-I became the king of Kanchipuram and wanted to enforce Shaivism as the state religion. He managed to convert all the Vaishnavas who were residents of Kanchipuram to Shaivism by force. He intended to extend this with an iron fist further but noticed that Swami Ramanujar

posed a great hindrance to this movement. Thus he summoned his two most trusted aides, Tirukkachi Nambi and Kurathazhwan, to his court and held a great philosophical debate. When he noticed that both Tirukacchi Nambi and Kurathazhwan were not budging from their claim of Narayana being the greatest among the trinity, he asked them to substantiate how anyone or anything in existence could rival Lord Shiva's presence in the universe. Kurathazhwan immediately spoke up, sighting *drona-charcha*, which says that the drona-pushpam, which sits atop the matted locks of Lord Shiva, is more significant than Lord Shiva. Hearing this, Kulothunga Chola became furious and decided to punish both Tirukacchi Nambi and Kurathazhwan. The king ordered his soldiers to gouge out their eyes. The soldiers gouged out Tirukacchi Nambi's eyes. Still, before they could get to Kuratazhwan, he said: "Whoever thinks/says that Supreme Lord Sriman Narayanan is equivalent/on par with or inferior with other devathas, that paaapam would catch me!" He then said there would be no bigger sin. Thus, he gouged out his own eyes and placed them in the hands of the soldiers.

Kulothunga Chola felt terrible for his doings and paid a beggar who was residing outside the palace to escort both of them to Sri Rangam. Tirukacchi Nambigal, by this time, was very old and said he could not face Swami Ramanujar as he had disgraced him and his principles and decided that it was time for him to depart to Paramapadam. Thus Tirukacchi Nambigal departed to Paramapadam. Soon the news reached Swami Ramanujar that Kulothunga Chola was planning to annex Sri Rangam and take Swami Ramanujar's life. Therefore, Swami Ramanujar departed from Sri Rangam and started to head north into Karnataka. By the time Swami Ramanujar and a few of his disciples reached Karnataka, it was quite late in the night, and they were in a dense forest. In

the darkness of night, a hunter's tribe offered to protect Swami Ramanujar and his disciples.

As they continued their journey by evening, they reached a house where they decided to stay the night. A few of Swami Ramanujar went into the house and found a woman who was buried in bhakti. She was performing aaradanam to a set of paduka. The disciples told her that they had come from the south and that they were looking for shelter for the night. The woman obliged. The disciples saw the paduka and asked her who her Acharya was. She told them that she had once visited Sri Rangam and had received divine instructions from an Acharya, but she soon forgot what she had learned. As luck would have it, she ran into her Acharya once again, but she did not see his face. She fell to his feet and told him that she had forgotten his instructions, and she wanted to learn his teachings once more. She said her Acharya recognized her bhakti and gave her his paduka, and she has been performing aaradanam to the paduka since that day. The disciples further probed her to see if she was speaking about Swami Ramanujar. They asked to describe the face of the Acharya she spoke about. She said she never saw his face and only fell at his feet as a mark of respect. She said that her Acharya's feet were like that of Sriman Narayana, like a lotus, and she could recognize his feet if she were ever to see them again. As she said this, Swami Ramanujar entered the room, and she saw his feet and immediately started to prostrate him, saying he was the Acharya whose paduka she had been serving earnestly. She gave Swami Ramanujar and his disciples shelter and guided them to Melukote (Tirunarayanpuram).

11.2.15 Tirunarayanapuram Vaibhavam



Swami Ramanujar reached Melukote (Tirunarayanapuram), and one night he had a divine dream where Sriman Narayana appeared and told Swami Ramanujar that he was very near him on the Yadugiri hill. He told Swami Ramanujar that He was awaiting Swami Ramanujar's arrival and that Swami Ramanujar would find Tiruman at the site

where He was present. Swami Ramanujar immediately sent out word to King Vishnuvardhan, who helped clear out the forests in the Yadugiri area. In clearing the woods, the soldiers found the Tirukalyani and a set of kaashayam at the site. They immediately returned to Swami Ramanujar, who came to the Tirukalyani, and looking at the kaashayam, understood that this was the site where Swami Dattatreya had taken up Sanyasam. Swami Ramanujar took a bath in the Tirukalyani and changed back into kaashayam. When Swami Ramanujar had left Sri Rangam, his disciples insisted that he wear white-colored clothing to avoid getting caught by Kulothunga Chola's soldiers. Swami Ramanujar found the Tiruman on the northwest banks of the Tirukalyani but could not find the Lord's idol. When Swami Ramanujar returned to his hermitage, he was disappointed as he could not find the Lord's idol. That night the Lord again appeared in Swami Ramanujar's dreams. He told him he could find the idol inside an anthill, which would be flanked by a Champaka tree, and Vakula Tree and Swami Ramanujar would find tulasi growing on the anthill. He also told Swami Ramanujar that the anthill would be located on the southwest bank of the Tirukalyani. Swami Ramanujar returned to the banks of the Tirukalyani the following day and discovered the divine anthill. Swami Ramanujar sent information to King Vishnuvardhan, who immediately rushed to Yadugiri to see the Lord. Swami Ramanujar performed ksheerabhishekam (abhishekam with milk) to the anthill. As the milk was poured on the anthill, it dissolved, showing a divine idol of the Lord. Swami Ramanujar personally performed punar-prathishtaapanam to the idol over three days. Soon the forests around the area were cleared entirely, and streets were constructed. A temple was erected at the site where the anthill stood, and sets of festivals were instituted.

The only missing entity at the time was an Utsava Murthy. Swami Ramanujar decided to recast the idols of Perumal and Thayaar using panchaloham (a mix of five holy metals in a particular proportion). That night, Sriman Narayana once again appeared in Swami Ramanujar's dreams and told him that His Utsava Murthy, Ramapriya, who was worshipped by Lord Rama, still exists and that the idol was residing in Delhi, which was under the Turk regime. The Lord told Swami Ramanujar to journey to Delhi and claim Him from the Turks. Swami Ramanujar made his journey to Delhi and went to the royal court of the Turk king and explained his situation. The king showed Swami Ramanujar the way into the treasury, where all the idols and plundered wealth were being kept. Swami Ramanujar searched the entire treasury but could not find the Lord's idol. Swami Ramanujar returned to the king's court and informed him that he was unable to find the Lord's idol. The king then personally took Swami Ramanujar to the queen's palace. The king told Swami Ramanujar that if the idol was still intact, it had to have been with one of the queens or one of the royal women. Swami Ramanujar started searching for the Lord's idol and saw that it was in possession of a princess. When Swami Ramanujar saw the Lord, his eyes swelled with tears of joy, and immediately he called out to the Lord, referring to him by the name of Selvapillai, and the idol of the Lord jumped from the window sill and ran towards Swami Ramanujar, into his hands. The king did not know what he had just seen. He was awestruck. The princess did not want to be separated from the idol as she had come to believe that the Lord was her husband and did not want to be separated from Him. The king then explained to his daughter that the idol did not belong with her and that they were foreigners who had to return to their land. Saying this, the king gave Swami Ramanujar his leave. Soon the princess started chasing after Swami Ramanujar and followed them to Tirunarayanapuram. Swami Ramanujar saw the bhakti in the

princess's intentions and allowed her to stay by the Lord's side and dubbed her Bibi Nachiyar.



Bibi Nachiyar



Vairamudi Utsavam

11.2.16 Swami Ramanujar's return to Sri Rangam and attaining Paramapadam

After Kulotunga Chola died in 1118, Swami Ramanujar decided to return to Sri Rangam. The people of Yadugiri could not bear to part with Swami Ramanujar. Thus, Swami Ramanujar instilled his qualities into a panchaloham idol. Swami Ramanujar and his disciples first made a stop at Tirumaliruncholai, where he fulfilled his vow to Sri Andal and presented the Lord with 100 gangalams of butter and sweet rice. After meeting his promise, he visited Srivilliputtur, where Sri Andal is said to have appeared before him and given him the title of Godaagraja. Swami Ramanujar then safely returned to Sri Rangam. When Kurathazhwan received the news of Swami Ramanujar's return, he rushed to see his Acharya. When Swami Ramanuja saw the plight of Kurathazhwan, he told Kurathazhwan to visit Varadaraja Perumal to regain his lost eyes. Kurthazhwan followed Acharya's instruction and restored his sight through the grace of Varadaraja Perumal. Kurathazhwan then served Swami Ramanujar for a period of two more years before attaining Paramapadam. Seventeen years after Kurathazhwan's demise, a time came when Swami Ramanujar sensed that his time on bhu-lokam was coming close to the end. It was at this time that Swami Ramanujar appointed Kurathazhwan's son Parashara Bhattar as the successor to propagate the Visishta Advaita Philosophy and made his final journey towards Paramapadam. The gist of his last teachings is as follows:

Worship all holy men precisely as you would do in the case of your spiritual preceptor. Have sincere faith in the teachings of the previous acharyas and Azhwars. Never become enslaved by your senses. Be not satisfied with the acquisition of worldly knowledge; spend your time reading literature which deals with the greatness of God and the wonders of His creation. By the Guru's grace, the attraction of the senses will cease to torment you. Learn to maintain composure in feelings of joy and sorrow, charm, and aversion. Enjoy the names and chanting of the glories of God's devotees with as much relish as the chanting of God's names and glories. Never forget that

service to the devotees of God is more significant than service to God Himself. He who renders service to God's devotees speedily attains God Himself. Do not take to the life of a devotee as a means for acquiring any selfish advantage.

11.3.1 Guru Parampara from Lord Sriman Narayana till Swami Ramanujar

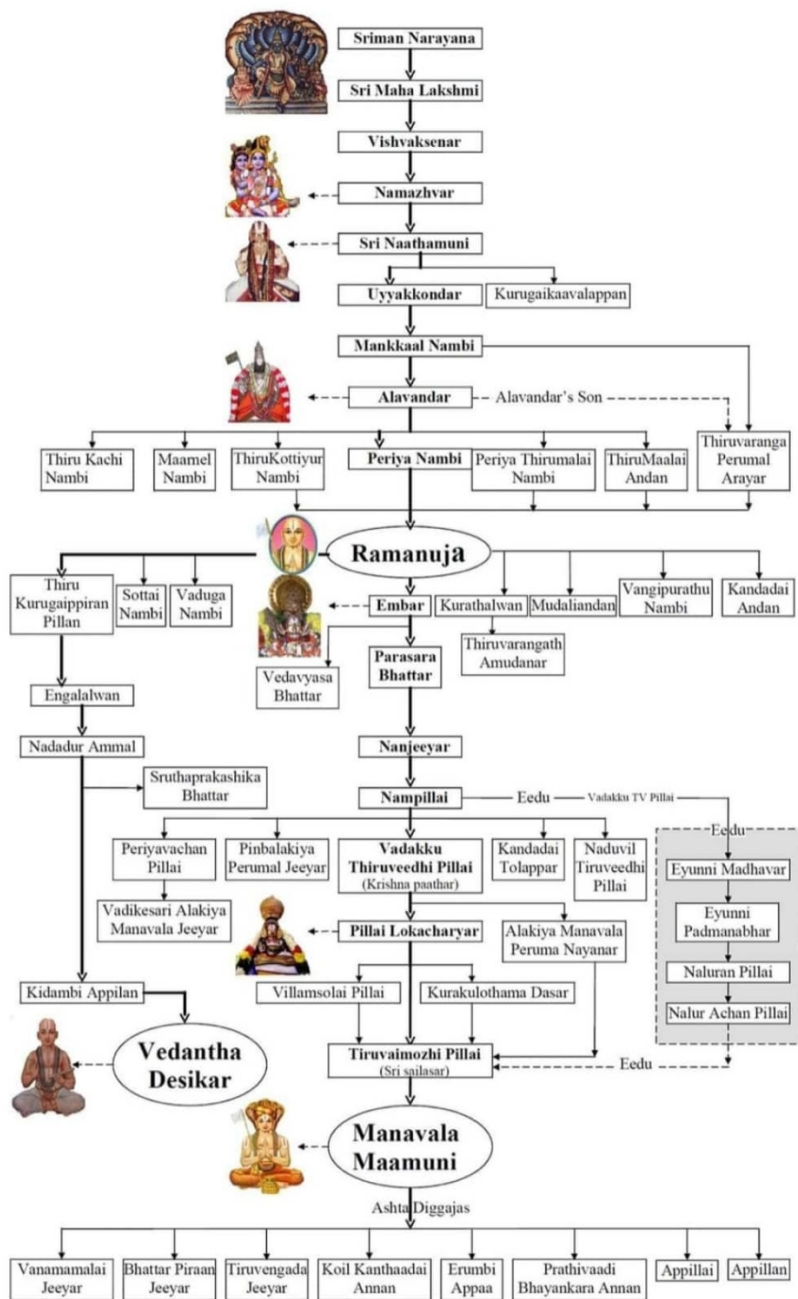
Sriman Narayana-> Mahalakshmi-> Vishvaksenar (Senainathan)-> Namazhwar-> Nathamunigal-> Manakkal Nambigal-> Aalavandhaar-> Periya Nambi-> Swami Ramanujar.

11.3.2 Guru Parampara from Ramanujacharya to Swami Desikan (Vadagalai Sampradayam)

Swami Ramanujar-> Tirukkurugai Pillan-> Sri Vishnu Chittar-> Sri Satya Vada Guru-> Kidambi Appular-> Swami Desikan.

11.3.3 Guru Parampara from Ramanujacharya to Manavala Mamunigal (Tenkalai Sampradayam)

Swami Ramanujar-> Embaar-> Parasara Bhattar-> Nanjiyar-> Nampillai-> Vadakkutiruviti Pillai-> Sri Pillailokacharyar -> Tirovazhimozhi Pillai-> Manavala Manmunigal.



11.3.4 Present Day Sri Vaishnava Mutts and Ashramams

To help aspirants seek out an Acharya, the mutts and Ashramams and their Jeeyars help and serve the Sri Vaishnava community. At present, several Sri Vaishnava Mutts and Ashramams are serving the community. In addition to the Acharyas of these mutts and Ashramams, many independent grihastha-acharyas are helping society.

Each of the Ashramams and mutts trace their roots back to Swami Ramanujar. Swami Ramanujar had appointed seventy-four *Simhasanadhipatis* to monitor, maintain, and propagate the Sri Vaishnava Parampara. Under Swami Desikan, the Parakala Mutt was established. The Ahobila Mutt, Srimad Andavan Ashramam, and the Sri Poundarikapuram Ashramam were established by the various successors of Swami Desikan. In the Tenkalai Sampradayam, Sri Manavala Mamunigal founded the Vanamamalai Mutt.

All one has to do is seek out and surrender to their Acharya, who, out of their infinite compassion, always welcomes the disciple and guides them in their spiritual journey.

12. Charama Shlokas

In the Vedanta school of thought, three shlokas stand out as a guiding factor to the three philosophies of Dvaita, Advaita, and Visisht Advaita. These three shlokas are referred to as charama shlokas.

The word charama in Sanskrit translates to ultimate or the total extreme. These shlokas are of such high regard as these were shlokas rendered by Lord Srīman Narayana in different situations but hold a fundamental and universal purpose. One can find three charama shlokas, namely, 1) Varaha Charama Shloka, 2) Rama Charama Shloka, and 3) Krishna Charama Shloka. The three charama shlokas form the basis for the Sri Vaishnava school of thought as given to us by Sri Ramanujacharya.

Now we shall see the Varaha Charma Shloka, its story, and its meaning.

The Varaha Charma Shloka can be found in the Varaha Puranam. The Varaha Puranam is one of the 18 celebrated Puranas of Indian literature. The Varaha Puranam

is a conversation between Lord Varaha and Bhoodevi as the Lord lifts Bhoodevi from the ocean of deluge after defeating Hiranyaksha.

The Varaha Charama Shloka is as follows,

स्थिते मनसि सुस्वस्थे शरीरे सति यो नरः ।
धातुसाम्ये स्थिते स्मर्ता विश्वरूपं च मामजं ॥
ततस्तं म्रियमाणं तु काष्ठ पाषाण सन्निभम् ।
अहं स्मरामि मद्भक्तं नयामि परमां गतिम् ॥



SrI BhUvarAha PerumAL

Sthite manasi susvasthe shareere sati yo narahaa I
Dhaatu-saamyee sthite smartaa Vishwaroopam ca Maamajam II

Tatas-tam mriyamaaNam tu kaashta paashaaNa sannibham I
Aham smaraami madbhaktam nayaami paramaam gatim II

Now to see the meaning of these two shlokas.

Lord Varaha addresses Mother Earth or Bhoodevi (who expresses concern for the well being of all Her children):

If anyone thinks of Me, when the mind is sound (sthite manasi), with the body in good health (suswasthe shareere), and with all mental and physical faculties working correctly and intact (dhaatu saamyee sthite) - thinks that I am indeed the very cause of

this universe (or the form of this universe, vishwaroopam), that I am without birth (ajam) - then I assure (You, Devi) that I will remember this devotee of Mine when they are on their death bed, lying (helplessly) like a stone or a log of wood, and personally take them to the Supreme Abode.

The doctrines of karma establish the laws that govern each jeevaathma. The aathma dwells in the body, which includes the senses and the mind. At death, when the soul departs from the body, it takes with it a load of character as developed by the activities it has so far undergone in its human host. This makes a start for its next host. As established by bhakti yogam, for one to achieve salvation, they must think of the Lord in their end moments. In the age of Kali Yugam, where people find it difficult to follow the established doctrines established in the scriptures, Bhoodevi, in her emotional attachment for all those borne by her to reach Vaikuntham and ended the cycle of life, asks the Lord what has to be done. The Lord then tells her to stop the cycle of rebirth; one must perform sharanagati or unconditionally to the Lord. If one unconditionally surrenders to the Lord and fails to remember him in their last moments, then the Lord himself will remember that jeevaathma and grant the soul salvation.

The Rama Charama Shlokam can be found in the Ramayana. This shloka is given to us by Lord Rama when Vibhishana approaches Rama and asks to be a part of his army. When Vibhishana approached Lord Rama to be a part of his army, Lord Rama asked the senior members of His military as to whether or not to accept his proposal. Lord Rama asks Sugriva, Nal, Neel, Angad, and Jambavan. All of them refuse to accept Vibhishana saying he was Ravana's brother. Finally, Lord Rama asked Hanuman for his opinion as he had traveled to Lanka and had seen the situation at ground zero.

Hanuman tells the Lord that among all the people he had seen in Lanka, Vibhishana was the only truly trustworthy person. He told the Lord that he was a pure bhakta, and the Lord could wholeheartedly trust him and harbor him. This was when the Lord gave us the second Charama Shloka. The Rama Charama Shloka is as follows,



Sakrud eva prapannaaya tavaasmeeti ca yaacate |
Abhayam sarva bhootebhyo dadaamyetad vratam ma-ma ||

सकुर्देव प्रपन्नाय तवास्मीति च याचते ।
अभयं सर्वभूतेभ्यो ददाम्येतत् व्रतं मम ॥

The meaning of the shloka is as follows,

To all those beings that wholeheartedly seek My shelter and plead for My mercy and say I am yours, I shall undoubtedly offer My protection to all of them. This is My vow. The Krishna Charama Shloka is considered to be the most revered among the three Charama Shlokas. It has been given commentary by many scholars from across different countries and across time immemorial.

This Charama Shloka can be found in Bhagavad Gita, the divine discourse given to Arjuna by Lord Krishna on the battlefield of Kurukshetra. Arjuna becomes overcome by emotion upon seeing members of his family in the opposition's army. It is then that

Lord Krishna tells Arjuna about Karma Yogam, Jnana Yogam, Bhakti Yogam, and various other methods on how to lead life. As a final commandment, the Lord tells Arjuna the Charama Shloka, which is the principal guiding factor of Sri Vaishnava philosophy.

The Shloka is as follows,



Sarva dharmān parityajya mām ekaṁ śaraṇam vraja ।
Ahaṁ tvāṁ sarva pāpēbhyo mokṣayishyāmi mā śucaha ॥
सर्वधर्मान् परित्यज्य मामेकं शरणं व्रज ।
अहम् त्वां सर्वपापेभ्यो मोक्षयिष्यामि मा शुचः ॥ ८ ॥

The meaning of the shloka is as follows,

Give up all (the other) dharmas and seek Me alone and My refuge. I will absolve you of all sins and liberate you. Do not despair. The Lord here tells Arjuna if one is not able to adhere to the principles of Jnana, Karma, and Bhakti, but in all profound heart surrenders his belief to the Lord, He will grant liberation from the cycle of life and death.

13. Stages of Bhakti Yoga

There are three stages to bhakti yogam, namely:

- (i) *Para bhakti*
- (ii) *Para jnanam*
- (iii) *Parama bhakti*

Saamanya Bhakti, or ordinary bhakti, leads to Para bhakti, where the seeker of moksha known as the *mumukshu* develops a keen desire to experience the Lord after climbing up the ladders of Karma Yoga, Jnana Yoga and necessarily realizing the nature of the jeevaathma and its relationship with the Paramaathma. The second stage of bhakti-yoga is Para jnanam, in which the intense desire of para bhakti is rewarded by the Lord when He grants *Paripurna sahakaaram*, which is full of bliss and enjoyment of His presence for a limited period. If, in this period, the practitioner develops a complete appetite for the Lord, His presence, and His form, then such a person becomes entitled to parama bhakti in which the mumukshu expresses his single desire, which is to be with the Lord at all times. The Lord acknowledges this desire and provides permanent *saakshatkaaram* wherein the Lord responds to any prayer made by the mumukshu granting him the final boon of eternal union with Himself or moksham.

The path of bhakti-yogam is very drawn out and often can start in one lifetime and continue to take roots in the following lifetimes. Hence, it becomes challenging to practice bhakti yogam in its entirety. Those who do not possess the knowledge or power to practice bhakti yogam in the time of kali-yugam are many. To help gain the fruits of bhakti-yogam, one can perform prapatti or sharanagati. The paths of prapatti are open to everyone and are not limited by any means to any varna-ashrama. As

prapatti or sharanagathi are the only alternatives to bhakti yogam, the acharyas now adopt this means for us to attain moksham.

Prapatti provides a simple and straightforward path that is bereft of the restrictions imposed by bhakti-yoga, which is very difficult and drawn out. There are three modes of prapatti, namely:

- (i) Sva-Nishta: Applicable to the Azhwars, Acharyas, and sages who have full knowledge of the Lord.
- (ii) Ukta-Nishta: Applicable to others who get initiated through an Acharya. The Acharya initiates the seeker through an Archaamurthi of the Lord.
- (iii) Acharya-Nishta: Applicable to those who cannot adopt any of the above two categories. In this case, the aspirant surrenders to an Acharya, and the Acharya, through his compassion, prays to the Lord on his behalf to grant him moksham.

14. Conclusion

The object and goal of life are that every human being should internally realize the divinity within himself and realize the unity with the Lord. The devotee who understands that he lacks the qualifications or the ability to follow Karma, Jnana, and Bhakti yogas as stipulated but possesses a longing desire to be united with the Lord has a sure and easy path laid out. All one has to do is seek out an Acharya and surrender to him with full confidence, absolute faith, and devotion. The disciple must learn to appreciate the teachings of the Acharya and see the Acharya as an equivalent

or a representative of the Lord Himself. Through being initiated by the Acharya and following his instructions, the disciple gains the fruits of dharma, artha, kama, and moksha. Ultimately, the Lord will shower his grace on such a person granting moksham or eternal bliss.

I would like to end this journey by paying obeisance to my Acharyas and the Lord.

" Acharyan Tiruvadigale Sharanam "

pallāṇḍu pallāṇḍu pallāyirattāṇḍu pala kōḍi nūrāyiram*
mallāṇḍa tintōḷ maṇivaṇṇā!* unśēvaḍi śevvi tirukkāppu*

aḍiyōmōḍum ninnōḍum pirivinṛi āyiram pallāṇḍu*
vaḍivāy ninvala mārbiniḷ* vāzginṛa maṅgaiyum pallāṇḍu*
vaḍivār śōḍi valatturaiyum* śuḍarāzium pallāṇḍu*
paḍaipōr pukku muzaṅgum* appāñjajanniyamum pallāṇḍē*

कायेन वाचा मनसेन्द्रियैर्वा

बुद्ध्यात्मना वा प्रकृतेः स्वभावात् ।

करोमि यद्यत्सकलं परस्मै

श्रीममन नरायणायेतिसमर्पयामि ॥

सर्व श्रीकृष्णार्पणम् अस्तु॥

